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'WPS clash deliberate, not a misunderstanding'

DND chief clarifies Bersamin's 'preliminary assessment'

By Charles Dantes, Rex Espiritu and Rachelle Tonelada

THE attack on Philippine Navy troops near Ayungin Shoal by China Coast Guard and militia on June 17 was "deliberate," the Defense and Foreign Affairs secretaries and the National Security Adviser said in a joint statement, departing from the earlier pronouncement of Executive Secretary that the incident was only a "misunderstanding."

Former US Air Force officer Ray Powell, for his part, said Bersamin's use of the words "misunderstanding" and "accident" were "unfortunate."

"This is clearly not an accident, it is clearly not a misunderstanding. These were deliberate acts by the China Coast Guard," Powell told ABS-CBN News in a virtual interview.

"I think that the idea behind using terms like that was toward de-escalation. But we need to be very careful when we consider de-escalation as an outcome, that we don't sort of fall into the trap," Powell added.

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NOT A MISUNDERSTANDING. Department of National Defense (DND) Secretary Gilberto Teodoro says the violent encounter between Philippine Navy sailors and Chinese forces in Ayungin shoal was deliberate and not an accident. He elaborated on a joint statement signed by National Security Council chief Eduardo Ano and Undersecretary Teresa Lazaro of the Department of Foreign Affairs at a press conference at the Malacanang Palace yesterday.

CL police chief under probe for possible POGO links



PHILIPPINE National Police (PNP) chief Rommel Francisco Marbil said on Monday that he placed the PNP Central Luzon Regional Director, Police Brigadier General Jose Hidalgo Jr., under investigation due to the discovery of the illegal Philippine Offshore

Gaming Operator (POGO) hubs in Bamban, Tarlac and Porac, Pangasinana.

"We are also investigating the regional director on the reports that were not acted upon properly. We put accountability there on the regional directors," General Marbil said at a press briefing.

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FULL SUPPORT. President Marcos Jr. emphasized anew the importance of the first BARMM elections in May 2025 in an address to officials of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region for Muslim Mindanao led by BARMM chief minister Ahod Ebrahim. Al Haj.

35 MEGAWORLD
A LASTING VISION



DID YOU KNOW?

Iconic McDonald's stores

Megaworld townships are known as homes to the most iconic McDonald's stores in the country. These include the 'most beautiful McDonald's' at The Upper East in Bacolod City; the sprawling McDonald's at Capital Town Pampanga known as the 'biggest McDonald's' in the country; and the 'first-ever McDonald's NXTGen store' in the whole Negros Island at Northhill Gateway just five minutes away from the Bacolod-Silay International Airport.



MEGAStan

Court sets De Lima free, dismisses last drug case

By Joel E. Zurbano

FORMER senator Leila de Lima was acquitted in the last remaining criminal charges against her, ending years of legal battles for one of the most vocal critics of former president Rodrigo Duterte and his deadly drug war.

Muntinlupa City Regional Trial Court Branch 206 Judge Gener Gito on Friday granted De Lima's demurrer in her last remaining drug case.

The former justice secretary had spent a decade investigating "death squad" killings allegedly orchestrated by Duterte until she was arrested in 2017 and spent more than six years in prison.

"I am now completely free and vindicated. It's very liberating," an emotional De Lima told reporters as she emerged from the courtroom.

"Despite the pain and injustice of it all, I went through it and endured the whole process."

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Rice traders assure Congress of lower prices

By Maricel V. Cruz

HOUSE Speaker Martin Romualdez was assured by leaders of the Philippine Rice Industry Stakeholders Movement (PRISM) on Monday that rice prices would significantly drop to as low as P42 per kilo next month.

PRISM founders Rowena Sadicon and Orly Manuntag met with Speaker

Romualdez and other leaders of the House of Representatives at the Manila Golf and Country Club in Makati City.

PRISM is a group composed of various stakeholders across the rice value chain from seed growers, farmers, millers to traders, importers and retailers.

Manuntag expressed his gratitude to the Speaker and other lawmakers for

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LOWER RICE PRICES. House Speaker Martin Romualdez stresses a point during a meeting with rice traders at Manila Golf and Country Club in Makati City on Monday morning. Ver Noveno

Let Sara speak for herself—Speaker

HOUSE Speaker Martin Romualdez said Monday that it should be Vice President Sara herself who should declare that she will be leading the opposition against the administration.

Lawyer Harry Roque, former spokesman during the administration of ex-president Rodrigo Duterte — had earlier an-

nounced that the vice president would now lead the opposition after she resigned last June 19 from the Cabinet and as secretary of education.

"I guess that's Mr. Harry Roque's statement but I guess we just have to hear it from the VP if and when the time comes

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BI, PRA sign data sharing agreement

By Vito Barcelo

THE Bureau of Immigration (BI) and the Philippine Retirement Authority (PRA) recently signed a data sharing agreement in a bid to prevent undesirable foreigners from using the country as a sanctuary to escape the crime they committed in their own country.

Representatives from the BI and PRA agreed to share data on derogatory records and travel history of applicants for retiree’s visa, which will be used in assessing their qualifications. By law, the PRA is mandated to process applications for Special Resident Retiree’s Visa (SRRV), to be issued to

foreign nationals opting to retire or reside permanently in the country. The SRRV is a special non-immigrant visa, which permits multiple entry and provides other benefits. The PRA issues this document to qualified foreign national retirees. Signing the agreement on behalf of the PRA were General Manager and CEO Roberto Zobrado and Department Manager Antonio Rivera. The BI, meanwhile, were represented by Commissioner Norman Tansingco and Legal Division Chief Arvin Santos. The initiative aims to expedite data exchange, facilitate smoother procedures for SRRV holders, and enable a more efficient monitoring system for immigration officers. The data sharing agreement introduces an advanced online/electronic system designed to facilitate the seamless exchange of information between the BI and PRA. This allows the PRA to access travel histories and simplify the verification of any derogatory records. Likewise, the system seeks to bolster the implementation of Republic Act No. 11032, also known as the Ease

of Doing Business and Efficient Government Service Delivery Act of 2018. Tansingco said the effort aims to assist the PRA in vetting foreign nationals applying for visas in the country. “This electronic data exchange system would allow for better monitoring, assisting the PRA in the implementation of their mandate, as well as allowing the BI to intercept foreign nationals with derogatory records attempting to reside in the country,” said Tansingco. The agreement shall be valid and effective for a period of five years, and subject to renewal every two years.

‘WPS... From A1

Defense Secretary Gilberto Teodoro Jr. said Bersamin's position, which came four days after the brutal attack that caused one Filipino soldier to lose his thumb, was only a “preliminary assessment.” “We see the latest incident in Ayungin not as a misunderstanding or an accident. It is a deliberate act of the Chinese officialdom to prevent us from completing our mission,” read the joint statement issued by Teodoro, acting Foreign Affairs Secretary Ma. Theresa Lazaro, and NSA Eduardo Año during a Palace briefing Monday. “After our visit to our troops in Palawan yesterday (Sunday), where the President personally talked to the troops involved in the RORE (rotation and reprovision mission) we have now come to a conclusion that it was not a misunderstanding or an accident.” “We are not downplaying the incident. It was an aggressive and illegal use of force,” the officials added. President Marcos also thumbed down Bersamin's recommendation

to announce RORE missions, Teodoro said. “The President has reiterated that we will not publish schedules of any RORE,” he said. “We reiterate that we seek neither permission nor consent from anyone in performing our sworn duties in the West Philippine Sea. In this regard we will continue our rotation and resupply missions on a regular basis, the welfare of our troops in the BRP Sierra Madre being a matter of utmost importance,” Teodoro added. On Friday, Bersamin said the Ayungin incident was a "misunderstanding" and should not be considered an armed attack that could trigger the country's Mutual Defense Treaty with the United States. “This was probably a misunderstanding or an accident. We're not ready to say this was an armed attack just yet,” Bersamin said. On Saturday, National Task Force on West Philippine Sea spokesperson Commodore Jay Tarriela echoed Bersamin's remarks, saying it was not China's intention to escalate tensions in the West Philippine Sea. “There is no reason for us to interpret this as an armed attack because

China's intention here is just to prevent the resupply from being successful...Basically, it's just a blockade,” Tarriela said. Teodoro, for his part, reaffirmed the country's commitment to both defending its territory and pursuing peaceful solutions through diplomatic channels. “We are a responsible state, but we will not be intimidated. Diplomacy is part of our responsibilities as a responsible country. This mandate comes strongly from our President and our armed forces to uphold our sovereignty,” he said. Lazaro said diplomatic efforts are ongoing, including the bilateral consultative mechanism on the South China Sea which is a long-standing forum for discussions with China. “We are doing something on the diplomatic front. We have a mechanism that has been in existence for quite a number of years. The last time we met was on January 17 when I went to Shanghai. We had discussions and came up with some confidence-building measures,” she said. Lazaro mentioned the possibility of another meeting in the near future, although dates have yet to be set.

"The Department of Foreign Affairs is clear on our direction, and we continue to engage in discussions with China through this consultative mechanism," she added. Meanwhile, the Australian ambassadors to Vietnam and the Philippines expressed their support to the United Nations Charter and the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) as the legally binding documents that “obligates us all.” Australian Ambassador to the Philippines Hae Kyong Yu said on X: “This commitment is a cornerstone of regional peace, security and prosperity.” US Assistant Secretary of State for East Asian and Pacific Affairs Daniel Kritenbrink over the weekend said China's recent actions were “deeply destabilizing.” “I wanna underscore the depth of our concern by many of the actions that we have seen that People's Republic of China did in the South China Sea. We think that China's action, particularly in its recent actions around Second Thomas Shoal (Ayungin) in the Philippines, have been irresponsible, aggressive, dangerous, and deeply destabilizing,” Kritenbrink said.

Our Lady of Loreto gets special crown from Pope



POPE Francis has granted the canonical coronation to the image of Our Lady of Loreto, patroness of Manila’s district of Sampaloc. The approval came more than two months after Cardinal Jose Advincula of Manila asked for the special crowning of the image, which is enshrined at the Archdiocesan Shrine of Our Lady of Loreto in Sampaloc. A pontifical coronation is a pious institutional act, wherein the Pope, through a Papal bull, designates a crown or stellar halo to be added to a Marian image under a specific devotional title in a particular area or diocese. The news was relayed to the shrine by the Dicastery for Divine Worship and the Discipline of the Sacraments in a letter dated May 6, but was only made public during Mass on Sunday, June 23. Fr. Enrico Martin Adoviso, the shrine's rector, said the image’s crowning with a “precious diadem” will be held on her feast day, December 10. The pontifical coronation, he added, will be led by Archbishop Charles Brown, apostolic nuncio to the Philippines, and Cardinal Advincula.

Court... From A1

The 64-year-old De Lima vowed that Duterte will not go scot-free for the drug war killings as well as her imprisonment. “This is my message to the former president, Mr Duterte: Now it's your turn to answer for your sins against the people,” she said. “I’m only one of the victims. Thousands of Filipinos were murdered during the bloody and fake ‘drug war.’ Many families lost loved ones. For those who weren’t killed, they were left languishing in jail because of the incorrect and twisted enforcement of the law. I’m one of those who have experienced unjust imprisonment,” De Lima added. De Lima had been freed on bail in November last year, having earlier been cleared of the two other drugs

charges. De Lima's counsel, Filibon Tacardon, said the prosecution failed to prove her guilt beyond reasonable doubt. In her petition filed in March, De Lima asked the court to dismiss the last drug case against her. The third and final case alleged that she accepted bribe money from convicted drug lords at the New Bilibid Prison during her term as justice secretary to finance her senatorial campaign. She has consistently denied any involvement in the illegal drug trade, asserting that she was a victim of political persecution due to her opposition to human rights abuses and killings associated with the drug war. She had maintained that the charges, which carried a maximum penalty of life in prison, were fabricated to silence her from criticizing Duterte's

narcotics crackdown that left thousands dead. Multiple witnesses, including prison gang bosses, died or recanted their testimonies during the lengthy trials. Also on Monday, the court dismissed another charge alleging De Lima had persuaded a former employee to ignore a 2016 summons issued by the House of Representatives for a hearing on the alleged trade of illegal drugs in Philippine prisons. That case, the only other criminal proceeding against her, had carried a penalty of anywhere between a fine and six months in prison. Senator Risa Hontivero said the dismissal of De Lima's third and last case “proves that justice is based on truth and evidence, not on baseless charges and political motivations.” “We need to focus our attention on those who have wrongly accused her. False charges compromise not

only the accused's reputation but also the integrity of our legal system. We call upon the authorities to pursue and hold accountable those who have perpetuated these unfounded allegations,” Hontiveros said. The ASEAN Parliamentarians for Human Rights said the dismissal of the case “Indicates that, despite the apparent flaws in the Philippine justice system, its judiciary remains independent.” “While we welcome this news, we also recognize that justice still needs to be served to not only Senator de Lima, but also to the countless other victims of the Philippines’ so-called ‘war on drugs.’ Therefore, we reiterate our call for Philippine authorities to open a thorough investigation into Senator de Lima’s arbitrary detention and hold all those responsible for this gross miscarriage of justice responsible,” APHR said in a statement. **AFP**

Rice... From A1

their fruitful discussions on stabilizing rice prices in the market in line with President Marcos’ Executive Order (EO) 62, which reduces the tariff on imported rice from 35 percent to 15 percent. Manuntag, who is also the spokesperson of the Grain Retailers Confederation of the Philippines, said the reduced tariff would be felt across the markets, especially by Filipino consumers. Sadicon, who is also PRISM’s lead convener, addressed the concerns of local farmers, assuring them that their interests would not be overlooked despite the tariff reduction. Also present during the meeting were House Committee on Appropriations Chairman Zaldy Co, House Committee on Agriculture and Food Chairman Mark Enverga, Deputy Majority Leader Erwin Tulfo, and National Food Authority OIC-Administrator Larry Lacson. Camarines Sur Rep. Luis Raymund Villafuerte meanwhile expressed optimism that the Senate will pass the bill that amends the Rice Tariffication Law (RTL) in the face of the rising cost of the staple. During a farmers' event in Quezon the other weekend, Romualdez had told reporters: It looks like the House and the Senate are coming to an agree-

ment and it looks close.” Romualdez said that reforming RTL was a "focal point" in his first official meeting with Senate President Francis Escudero at Malacañan Palace. He said the proposed amendments aim to ensure food security and economic stability for farmers by providing affordable quality rice to Filipinos and increasing farmers’ incomes. Villafuerte said that the likely congressional approval of the proposed amendatory law to RTL or Republic Act 11203 will further pull down market prices of this grain, as part of the government's aim to slash the per-kilo price of rice to below P30 for the benefit of consumers. “With rice accounting for a sizeable share of the food expenses of Filipinos, most especially of poor or low-income families, amending RA 11203 by restoring certain regulatory and trading powers of the NFA (National Food Authority) to intervene in the market and make the staple more affordable and accessible for our consumers is one way for lawmakers to help take the edge off sticky inflation,” the lawmaker said. Villafuerte, a lead proponent of the House-passed amendatory measure (House Bill or HB 10381) to RA 11203, is more hopeful now that senators would pass their version of the proposed amendments to the RTL when the 19th Congress reopens for its third and final session on July 22.

CL... From A1

Marbil had earlier warned cops they will face disciplinary actions if found to be involved in the operations of illegal POGOs. “This policy serves as a reminder: engage in illegal activities, and you will be dealt with accordingly,” he said. But Marbil said he will not go as far as saying that policemen have been found to be "protectors" of illegal POGOs. He said concerned police officials have been relieved from their posts due to lack of action. “I don't want to say protector because there really is no protector. We have our integrity monitoring group that is checking on our people and I guess what we are chasing is the inefficiency of our officers,” Marbil said. In the POGO hub in Porac, police and the Presidential Anti-Organized Crime Commission (PAOCC) had found items used for torture, and some devices used for cloning SIM cards and for sending

out text blasts. Meanwhile, six Chinese POGO workers from the raided hub in Bamban, Tarlac were found to be fugitives facing charges in their country. The Chinese had warrants of arrest for fraud, operating gambling dens and other crimes. Lucky South 99 Corp. , the operator of the POGO hub, has rejected the allegations made by the Presidential Anti-Organized Crime Commission (PAOCC) claiming that the company was conducting business illegally. Jovito Barte, the company's lawyer, stated that the firm originally held a probationary license approved by the Philippine Amusement and Gaming Corporation (Pagcor). However, the same government agency revoked the license on May 22. The PAOCC conducted a raid on the LS99 compound in Porac, Pampanga, on June 3, more than a week after the license was revoked. Barte clarified that while it was true that the company no longer had a li-

cense, it was inaccurate to declare that it was operating illegally. He mentioned that the company had completely ceased all operations by that time and was in the process of winding down its affairs when the raid occurred. LS99 had 7,000 employees, with the majority being foreigners, including Chinese, Vietnamese, Malaysians, and individuals from other nationalities. Only 1,200 employees were Filipino, working as guards and maids. To date, LS99 has paid Pagcor \$300 million for the privilege of operating as an internet gaming company. The company's assets, including the 46 buildings in the compound, as well as the computers, cellphones, and other equipment, are valued at least at P600 million. Meanwhile, a manager of the raided Philippine Offshore Gaming Operator (POGO) hub in Porac, Pampanga was prevented from leaving the country, the Presidential Anti-Organized Crime Commission (PAOCC) said Monday. PAOCC spokesperson Dr. Winston Casio said the manager was offloaded on Sunday in Davao.

Let... From A1

for her to make statements on policies of the national government,” Romualdez told reporters on Monday. The House Speaker said he respected

her decision to step down and wished her well. “We miss the closer interactions that we had during the campaign,” said Romualdez. “We wish her always the best of luck in all endeavors and in her service to the Filipino people,” he said.

Romualdez and Duterte were both members of Lakas-CMD, where Romualdez sits as its president and Duterte is chairperson. Duterte resigned from Lakas after Pampanga 2nd District Representative Gloria Macapagal Arroyo was stripped of her post as senior deputy speaker in May 2023

IN BRIEF

Imee eyes reelection, not Manila mayor post

SENATOR Imee Marcos on Monday said she is seeking reelection in the upcoming 2025 elections, denying she will run for mayor of Manila or any local government unit (LGU).

However, the senator said she has not yet decided if she will run under the administration, saying they already have many "senatoriables." "I am still confused, but let us see," Marcos said, adding there is still more time.

Meanwhile, she affirmed her support for Vice President Sara Duterte despite the latter's resignation as secretary of the Department of Education. "Whatever happened, my trust and love for VP Sara will remain," Marcos said.

Asked if the Hugpong ng Pagbabago will endorse her, Marcos said the party is yet to meet. She is set to run for a second term as senator, previously serving as congresswoman and governor of Ilocos Norte. **Macon Ramos-Araneta**

Generals, senior naval officers await CA nod

THE commander of the armed forces in the disputed West Philippine Sea (WPS) heads the list of 15 newly promoted generals and senior naval officers whose papers have been forwarded by Malacañang to the congressional Commission on Appointments (CA) for confirmation hearings.

"The CA has received the appointment papers of Philippine Navy Rear Admiral Alfonso Torres, Jr., who has been promoted to the rank of vice admiral," CA Assistant Minority Leader and Surigao del Sur Rep. Johnny Pimentel said in a statement on Monday.

Torres is the head of the military's unified Western Command that oversees the WPS. The command is based in Camp General Artemio Ricarte in Puerto Princesa City, Palawan. The naval rank of vice admiral, or three stars, is equal to lieutenant general in the other armed services.

"We have also received the papers of Philippine Army Maj. Gen. Fernando Reyeg, who has been promoted to the rank of lieutenant general," Pimentel said. Reyeg is head of the military's unified Visayas Command based in Cebu City. **Maricel V. Cruz**

CA denies Bantag plea to nullify murder charges in Mabasa death

Rey E. Requejo

THE Court of Appeals (CA) has denied the plea of former Bureau of Corrections chief Gerald Bantag seeking to nullify the murder charges filed by the Department of Justice (DOJ) against him and several others, in connection with the killing of radio broadcaster Percival "Percy Lapid" Mabasa and Bilibid inmate Jun Villamor in October 2022.

In a four-page resolution authored by Associate Justice Ronaldo Roberto Martin, the CA's Second Division upheld the orders issued by the Regional Trial Court of Las Piñas City on November 16, 2023 order and February 26, denying the motion to quash information and warrant of arrest issued by the court following his indictment for murder cases.

The appellate court dismissed Bantag's appeal for his failure to follow procedural rules on filing a petition for certiorari.

The CA noted that Bantag's camp failed to secure the conformity of the Office of the Solicitor General (OSG) in filing the petition.

The appellate court cited a Supreme Court ruling that previously held that "only the OSG may bring or defend actions on behalf of the Republic of the Philippines, or represent the People or State before the SC and the CA."



'LAB FOR ALL.' Hundreds flock to the 'Lab for All' program of First Lady Liza Araneta-Marcos to avail of the free government and healthcare services at a gymnasium in Barangay Addition Hills, Mandaluyong City on Monday. **Manny Palmero**

Iloilo town wins P1m for Independence Day float

By Caloy Lozada

THE Iloilo Provincial Government has awarded Santa Barbara P1 million for its winning entry in the "Parada ng Kalayaan," as part of the 126th Philippine Independence Day Celebration held on June 12 in Manila.

The symbolic check was personally handed over by Governor Arthur Defensor, Jr. to Santa Barbara Mayor Dr. Dennis Superficial in a recent ceremony.

The winning float, themed "Cry of

Santa Barbara," captured the essence of the town's rich historical legacy, impressing judges and earning top honors in the parade.

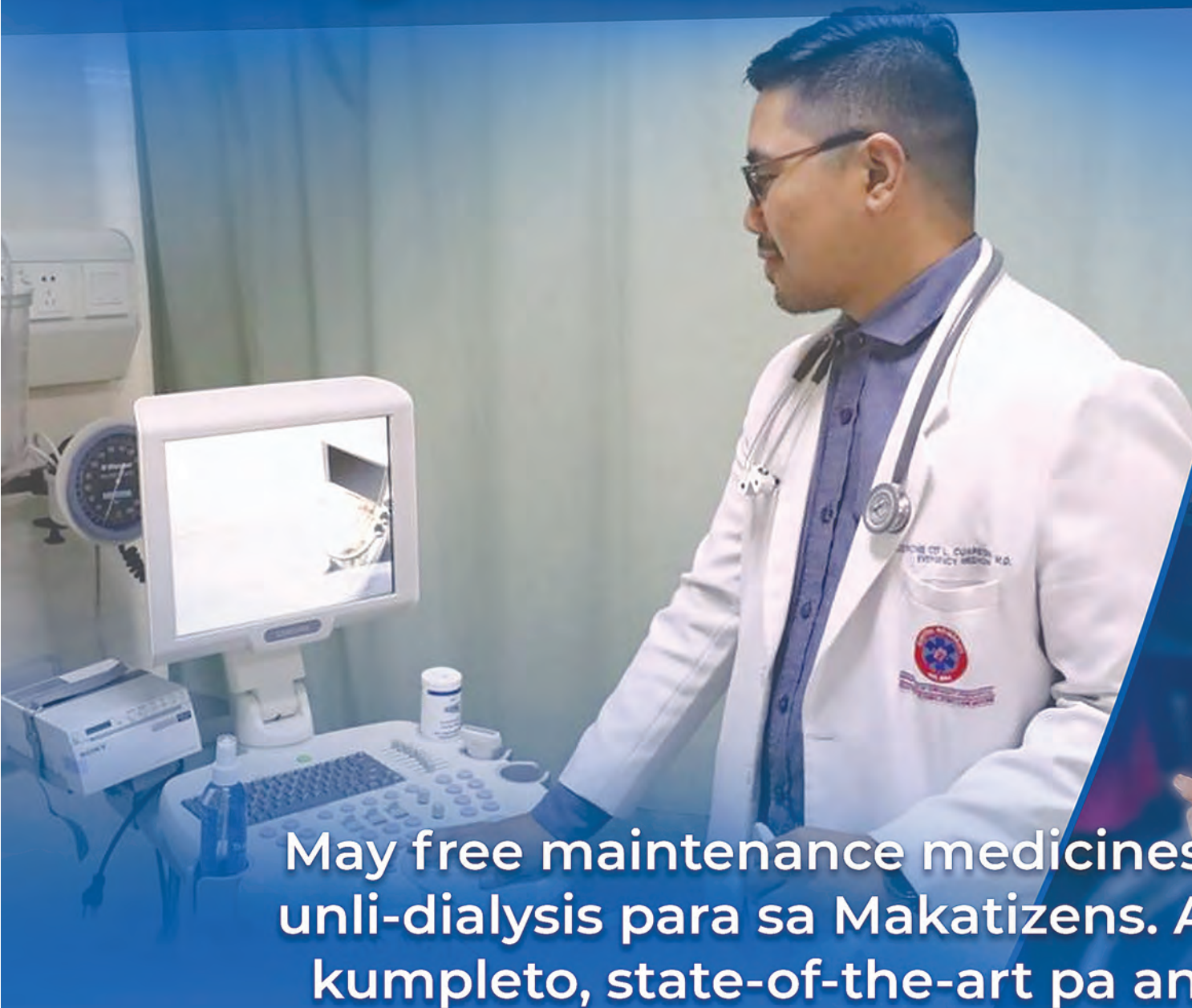
Mayor Superficial was accompanied by Vice Mayor Isabelo Maquino, Sangguniang Bayan Members Ramon Julius Sodusta, Christine Delgado, Charles Badon, Cris Collada, Atty. Porchia Maquino, Timotheo Padilla, Neil Superficial, SK Federation President Nikka Joan Suganob, and Ex Officio Board Member Ramon Sullano.

Defensor expressed his heartfelt

gratitude to all those who contributed to the creation and beautification of the float. He specifically praised the efforts of both the provincial government and Santa Barbara officials for their dedication to highlighting the town's historical significance.

"This victory is not just a win for Santa Barbara, but for the entire province of Iloilo," said Defensor. "It started with a simple invitation to participate in the parade, and now it has turned into a monumental achievement that showcases our rich cultural heritage."

Para sa Makatizens, ang health programs, better!



May free maintenance medicines, pa-ospital, unli-dialysis para sa Makatizens. At hindi lang kumpleto, state-of-the-art pa ang facilities.



Pimp who sells minors online faces trafficking raps—DOJ

By Rey E. Requejo

THE Department of Justice (DOJ) has filed before the Calamba, Laguna Regional Trial Court multiple criminal charges against a pimp who allegedly peddled online young boys to foreigners for live sex or explicit photos/videos in exchange for money.

In a 10-page resolution, the DOJ Task Force on Women and Children and Against Trafficking in Persons found probable cause to indict respondent Jhon Patrick Carmona for qualified trafficking in persons under Republic Act (RA) No. 9208 (Anti-Trafficking in Persons Act of 2003) as further amended by RA No. 11862 (Expanded Anti-Trafficking in Persons Act of 2022).

“Respondent Carmona committed trafficking in persons, since he offered the sexual services of the three vulnerable minor victims to the undercover foreigner for a fee,” the DOJ resolution stated.

The task force headed by deputy state prosecutor Olivia Laroza-Torrevillas and senior assistant state prosecutor Josie Christina Dugay charged Carmona with three counts of qualified trafficking of minors.

The Task Force recommended no bail

for each of the charges.

Meanwhile, the complaint for violation of RA No. 11930 (Online Sexual Abuse or Exploitation for Children (OSAEC) and Child Sexual Abuse or Exploitation Materials (CSAEM) was referred for further preliminary investigation.

Acting on a tip from the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) about the distribution of Child Sexual Abuse and Exploitation Materials (CSAEM) by the accused, the National Bureau of Investigation-Human Trafficking Division (NBI-HTRAD) discovered an X account (formerly Twitter) allegedly used by the respondent to sell young boys to foreigners.

Using undercover agents, the NBI-HTRAD was able to establish a series of communications with the respondent, mostly involving the suspects’ demand for money in exchange of lewd photos/videos of young boys via messaging application Telegram.

As the familiarity between the undercover agents and respondent grew, the respondent offered to meet-up with the undercover agent on the suspect’s offer of three young boys for sex.

A rescue operation was laid out and Carmona was arrested while the three young were recovered.



‘ZUMBASAAN’ IN CAVITE. Hundreds of local residents mostly mothers joined a disaster preparedness campaign dubbed Zumbasaan, organized by the local government and held at the SM Tanza parking area in Barangay Daang Amaya II in Tanza, Cavite on Monday, June 24, 2024. Dennis Abrina

PNP confiscates P13.6b-illegal drugs, arrests 28,800 suspects in Jan-June

By Vince Lopez

DEPARTMENT of the Interior and Local Government (DILG) Secretary Benjamin Abalos Jr. on Monday disclosed that the Philippine National Police (PNP) has confiscated a some P13.6 billion worth of illegal drugs from January 1 to June 21 this year

In a press briefing held in Camp Crame in Quezon City, Abalos said the operations also resulted in the arrest of 28,804 suspects.

The seized illegal drugs consisted of 1,779.74 kilos (kg) of shabu; 3,559.04 kg. of dried marijuana; 4,951,655 pieces of marijuana plants; 26.62 kg. of cocaine and 4.17 kg. of ecstasy.

The DILG chief commended the top three performing PNP units in the campaign --the Police Regional Office (PRO) 4A (Calabarzon) and PRO 7 (Central Visayas), and the PNP Drug Enforcement Group (DEG).

From June 17 to 21, Abalos said the PNP’s intensified drive led to the arrest of 1,197 suspects in the wanted list, including 347 tagged as “most wanted.”

The secretary said those arrested included former Negros Oriental Gov. Pryde Henry Teves, who was nabbed on June 20 and was charged with three counts of terrorism financing, with a recommended bail of P200,000 per count.

Teves was later released after posting P600,000-bail for his temporary liberty.

Abalos said the PNP also apprehended 106 people for i legal possession of firearms, resulting in the confiscation of 183 firearms.

Meanwhile, PNP chief Gen. Rommel Francisco Marbil said they are in the process of reviving the 911 emergency hotline to ensure the quick response of police officers to incidents.

“It’s old that you hear why the police are slow but now, it’s fast. This is what we are doing and you will see many accomplishments, this is the New Philippines, what the police want, you are safe,” he added.

IN BRIEF

Acosta bags two Gawad Dangal Filipino Awards

PUBLIC Attorney’s Office (PAO) chief Persida Rueda-Acosta has bagged two Gawad Dangal Filipino Awards 2024 for exemplary leadership and outstanding public service.

Dr. Romm Burlat, Gawad Dangal Filipino Awards president and chief executive officer, adjudged Rueda-Acosta as the recipient of the Lifetime Achievement Award for Female Leadership, and the Dr. Jose Rizal Leadership Award.

The awarding ceremony was held recently at the Sequoia Hotel Manila Bay in Parañaque City.

In her acceptance speech, Acosta conveyed gratitude to Gawad Dangal Filipino Awards for recognizing her dedication and commitment to help the poor and surpass what is expected of PAO’s services.

The two awards represented the 36th and 37th trophies the PAO chief has so far received in recognition in recognition of here exemplary services.

She cited the trust, confidence and support of the indigent Filipino people and all sectors of society amid the adversities in fighting for the country. **Rio N. Araja**

21 Imus couples say ‘I do’ simultaneously

IMUS CITY—Twenty one couples exchanged marital vows at a mass wedding here organized by the local government’s June Bride Mass Wedding held here on Wednesday, June 19, at the function hall of the New Imus City Government Center in Barangay Malagasang 1-G.

Mayor Alex Advincula organized the nuptials called “Kasalang Imuseño” in collaboration Rep. Adrian Advincula of 3rd District of Cavite while City Hall deputy chaplain Ramil Ilano blessed the newly wed couples.

The couples received pillows, appliances, and monetary gifts from the local government of Imus.

According to the city civil registrar, a total of 527 couples have so far tied the knot in the Kasalang Imuseño program that started in August 2022 for unwed partners, especially those who have been together for a long time but could not get married due to financial constraints.

Solon says use of existing VCMs for ‘25 polls will save gov’t P8b

By Maricel V. Cruz

A LEGISLATOR has urged the Commission on Elections (Comelec) to consider reusing its existing vote-counting machines (VCMs) in next year’s midterm polls to save the government close to P8 billion.

The amount to be saved, according to Rizal Rep. Emigdio Tanjuatco III, can instead be spent on much-needed public goods and services.

Tanjuatco echoed the suggestion of his fellow legislators who are pushing for the use of the 97,000 VCMs earlier bought from Smartmatic. This, with lingering concerns on the unreliability of the new “hybrid” voting and counting system contracted by the Comelec casting a shadow on the less-than-a-year of preparations for the national and local elections in May 2025.

“First and foremost, the P18-billion contract between the Comelec and Miru Systems Co. Ltd. does not comply with the terms of reference (TOR) of the automated election system (AES). I was present during the first demo of Miru’s machines in the Comelec, where I witnessed

the deficiencies first hand,” said Tanjuatco, a member of the House Committee on Suffrage and Electoral Reforms.

Specifically, Tanjuatco questioned the integrity of vote-counting, saying he personally saw that Miru’s prototype machine read crumpled, marked and torn sample ballots during the demo in February.

“The Rizal lawmaker likewise decried the railroading of the contract signing despite mounting calls for the Comelec to first look into the controversies surrounding Miru’s bid, especially the South Korean firm’s submission of an unused prototype -- a practice disallowed by the law.

Similarly, the Supreme Court had ruled that the Comelec committed a grave abuse of discretion when it disqualified Smartmatic from the bidding, making Miru the lone bidder and paving the way for it to bag the deal despite disturbing reports of incompetence in the elections it had handled in countries such as the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Iraq, among others.

On top of the irregularities hounding the biggest-ever contract awarded by the



CHINESE MILITARY UNIFORMS. Senator Sherwin Gatchalian looks at some Chinese military uniforms during an ocular inspection at Lucky South 99 Outsourcing, Inc. on Monday, June 24, with Presidential Anti-Organized Crime Commission chief Undersecretary Gilbert Cruz. It was unclear where the camouflage uniforms came from. **Danny Pata**

PCUP-PSA tie-up to enhance civil registry

By Rio N. Araja

THE Presidential Commission for the Urban Poor (PCUP) has partnered with the Philippine Statistics Authority (PSA) through a memorandum of agreement to bolster the provision of civil registry documents and other critical services to the urban poor.

PCUP chairman and chief executive officer Elpidio Jordan Jr. said the collaboration underscores a joint commitment to streamline services and improve the quality of life for the disadvantaged communities.

The agreement was signed by Jordan and PSA deputy national statistician Civil Registration and Central Support Office acting chief Clemente Manaoag, representing national statistician and Civil Registrar General Undersecretary Claire Dennis Mapa to cement a comprehensive partnership between the two agencies.

Under the arrangement, the PCUP will provide the necessary logistical support, including venues, equipment and promotion of PSA services through various media platforms.

For its part, the PSA would participate in PCUP events and provide technical assistance and informational resources.

“This partnership with the PSA marks a significant milestone in our journey to provide essential services such as civil registration, which is a fundamental right and a vital component for accessing various government services,” Jordan said.

Manaoag stressed that the PSA is ready to assist the PCUP in meeting the needs of vulnerable sectors to ensure their identity from birth to death.

The MOA will be effective for four years from 2024 to 2027 with a mandatory review before renewal to assess progress and make necessary adjustments.



TRILATERAL MARITIME EXERCISES. The Philippine Coast Guard vessel BRP Gabriela Silang, along with Japan Coast Guard’s PLH 02 Tsugaru and Indonesia Coast Guard’s KN Trisula P11, arrives at the Bredco port in Bacolod City Monday for six-day, three-way maritime exercises on search and rescue, firefighting, oil spill recovery, equipment recovery, and damage assessment. The drills also showcase the interoperability among the three states in protecting their seas and maritime borders during emergency situations. **Nanette Guadalquivier**

REPUBLIC OF THE PHILIPPINES
COMMISSION ON APPOINTMENTS
ANNOUNCEMENT

President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr. has submitted to the Commission on Appointments (CA), for confirmation, the *ad interim* appointments of the following Generals/Flag Officers of the Armed Forces of the Philippines (AFP):

1. ALFONSO F. TORRES JR.	to the rank of VICE ADMIRAL
2. PEDRO C. BALISI JR.	to the rank of MAJOR GENERAL
3. JIMMY D. LARIDA	to the rank of MAJOR GENERAL
4. ROY VINCENT T. TRINIDAD	to the rank of REAR ADMIRAL
5. JOE ANTHONY C. ORBE	to the rank of REAR ADMIRAL
6. ROY ANTHONY O. DERILLO	to the rank of BRIGADIER GENERAL
7. ROMAN M. DIOSO	to the rank of BRIGADIER GENERAL
8. CONSTANCIO ARTURO M. REYES JR.	to the rank of COMMODORE

The public may submit any information, written report, or sworn/notarized complaints or oppositions to the above *ad interim* appointments in seven (7) copies to the CA Secretariat, 6th Floor, PNB Financial Center, D. Macapagal Blvd., Pasay City, Metro Manila.

For the schedule of the public hearings, the CA Secretariat can be reached through telephone numbers 8834-2713, 8831-1824, 8831-0527, 8832-9830, 8834-2706 and 8851-1989.

20 June 2024.

MYRA MARIE D. VILLARICA
Secretary



To The Point
Emil P. Jurado

Interesting days ahead

VICE President Sara Duterte did the long-expected resignation from the Marcos Cabinet as secretary of education.

After months of the long-soured relationship of the so-called UNITEAM of President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr. and Vice President Sara Duetrrte, she did the inevitable and resigned from the Marcos Cabinet.

What the Vice President did was no surprise to many since most knew the Vice President would resign finally.

Now, may the Vice President be the leader of the opposition?

Most of the self-appointed pundits and analysts are going to town speculating on what will happen, especially in 2025, next year, being a midterm election year.

With the former President Rodrigo Duterte running for the Senate and with his daughter leading the opposition, Santa Banana, it would be interesting days ahead.

Recall the former President had even called BBM a “drug addict,” a “spoiled child,” and a “weak leader,” but BBM laughed them off.

Recall also the First Lady Liza Araneta Marcos got into the picture when she reacted to the fact that the Vice President laughed and seemed to enjoy the Davao City rally where Marcos Jr. was called a drug addict.

But, what bothers a lot of people is that political bickering at this time when China is becoming so aggressive at the West Philippine Sea and especially at the Exclusive Economic Zone, in the disputed waters and shoals like Ayungin (Second Thomas Shoal) and the Panatag Shoal off Zambales at Bajo de Masinloc is misplaced.

China had threatened trespassers, that means us, Filipinos, would be detained for three months, and banned fisherfolk from Bajo de Masinloc.

In fact, China’s Coast Guard vessels boarded a Philippine vessel on a resupply mission to Filipino navy men aboard the grounded World War II BRP Sierra Madre at Ayungin Shoal. hurting at least seven crewmen and seizing food provisions.

We still have to know what the Vice President has to say about these.

With Sara’s temperament, what will she say against China?

Will father and daughter continue their word war with Marcos Jr.?

To me, political bickering at this point is like a hole in the head. All this can only turn off foreign investors, and negatively affect economic growth.

It would truly be interesting what the Dutertes, being oppositionists, will do if and when President Marcos will fi-

nally decide to join the United Nations Rome Statute which would mean rejoining the International Criminal Court, and allowing the investigation force to continue investigation of the extrajudicial killings during the six-year term of Sara’s father.

Recall that Sara, the mayor of Davao City, was included among those being investigated by the ICC, together with Senator “Bato” dela Rosa and others.

I won’t second guess what would happen next once the ICC would issue a warrant of arrest against the Dutertes on crimes against humanity.

Interesting days ahead, but lamentably not good for the Philippines.

Sara preparing for 2028

Clearly, Sara Duterte is preparing herself to be a presidential candidate in 2028.

I hate to say it since 2028 is too far off to speculate on anything.

But in the Philippines, politics is a never-ending activity.

Political bickering at this point is like a hole in the head. All this can only turn off foreign investors, and negatively affect economic growth

With the resignation of the Vice President from the Cabinet, it gives her all the time to prepare for 2028.

Indeed, interesting days are ahead. Unfortunately, not for the country facing threats of imminent war.

While war may not be unavoidable, at this time all these are a hole in the head. It may be beneficial to the Dutertes to prepare this early. But, between now and 2028, many things can happen, and will happen.

The Singapore strongman Lee Kuan Yew once said after a visit to the Philippines that “They (the Philippines) have too much politics.”

Look at Vietnam which has surpassed the Philippines in economic development.

They have no elections, while we in the Philippines eat politics for breakfast, lunch and dinner.

Clearly, Sara is overestimating herself as an opposition leader.

Traditional oppositionists, like former Senator Leila de Lima, Albay Rep. Edcel Lagman and others, are balking at Sara being the opposition leader.

stage, could lose him the November election.

‘Insult-laden tirades’

The debate comes in the wake of a criminal trial that has consumed Trump’s attention for months -- with his sentencing on 34 convictions for falsifying business records scheduled for July 11.

Both candidates shunned the bipartisan commission that has run debates since 1988, deciding instead to go with CNN for a first showdown unusually early in the year, and another on ABC on September 10.

Debates are about soundbites on social media as much as policy arguments, and both candidates will look for explosive viral moments

Abortion, the state of US democracy and foreign conflicts are all issues of concern to voters, although inflation and border security are likely to loom largest.

The last debates between the two men in 2020 were fraught, with Biden at one point snapping “will you shut up, man?” as Trump repeatedly interrupted him.

This time, moderators have more tools than usual to maintain decorum, with the microphones muted except for the candi-

PRESIDENT Ferdinand Marcos Jr.’s statement the Philippines will not use force or intimidation, inflict injury or harm anyone, amid rising tensions in the West Philippine Sea rustles like a breath of fresh air.

“We are not in the business to instigate wars-- our great ambition is to provide a peaceful and prosperous life for every Filipino,” the President said during the Talk To Troops at the Western Command Headquarters in Camp General Artemio Ricarte in Puerto Princesa.

The President was in Palawan, six days after Filipinos on a rotation and resupply mission were injured in a ramming incident between China Coast Guard and Filipino boats.

It was the latest and most serious incident in a series of escalating confrontations between Chinese and Philippine ships in recent months as Beijing steps up efforts to push its claims to nearly all of the strategic watercourse.



Citizen Barok
Louis ‘Barok’ Biraogo

IN A high-stakes game of geopolitical brinkmanship, China’s choice to wield axes, knives, and engage in “jostling” rather than conventional, high-tech weaponry in its territorial disputes is both a deliberate and dangerous tactic.

This week, the South China Sea became the latest theater for this peculiar strategy, with Chinese Coast Guard members reportedly using pickaxes and knives against Philippine naval forces.

The choice of these rudimentary tools over firearms is revealing—and alarming.

The use of simple weapons is not new for China.

In fact, it mirrors past confrontations along the Sino-Indian border, where similar methods were employed.

The logic behind this tactic, as noted by experts, is to manage the risk of escalation.

By avoiding the use of firearms, China ostensibly reduces the likelihood of triggering a full-scale war, particularly one that could invoke international defense treaties.

Yet, this approach is fraught with peril.

At the core, China’s reliance on non-lethal yet provocative tools appears to serve multiple objectives.

Firstly, it blurs the lines of engagement, creating ambiguity that complicates the application of defense treaties like the 1951 mutual defense agreement between the United States and the Philippines.

As Daniel Mattingly from Yale University points out, this ambiguity makes it harder for the US to justify intervention, thus giving China more room to maneuver without crossing a clear red line.

Secondly, this tactic seeks to avoid drawing the intense scrutiny and condemnation that would inevitably follow the use of more conventional, deadly force.

The sight of axes and knives, while still menacing, does not carry the same immediate connotation of war as gun-

date whose turn it is to speak.

“Trump is notoriously undisciplined and is likely to chafe at not being able to dominate the event by talking over his opponent and drawing out time with his long-winded, insult-laden tirades,” said political scientist Nicholas Creel, of Georgia College and State University.

“Biden is also counting on this debate reminding Americans of the chaos that was the Trump presidency, so Trump being unable to abide by the rules and performing poorly as a result is a very striking possibility.”

More ‘presidential’?

EDITORIAL

Manila Standard

Ahead of the curve

The CCG deemed its moves as “control measures” in line with its mythical nine-dash line claim of sovereignty in almost the entire South China Sea, including most of the West Philippine Sea, despite a 2016 international tribunal ruling that effectively dismissed its claims stemming from a case filed by Manila in 2013.

The Philippines has its BRP Sierra Madre where Marine troops live on since 1999 in Ayungin Shoal, also known as Second Thomas Shoal, with Beijing demanding its removal, such demand rejected by Manila.

“
The confrontation has stoked up concern the dispute could drag in the United States, which has a mutual defense pact with Manila

The confrontation has stoked up concern the dispute could drag in the United States, which has a mutual defense pact with Manila.

Only last year, Pentagon said: “The guidelines reaffirm that an armed

attack in the Pacific, including anywhere in the South China Sea, on either of their public vessels, aircraft, or armed forces -- which includes their Coast Guards -- would invoke mutual defense commitments under Articles IV and V of the 1951 US-Philippines Mutual Defense Treaty.”

Some security analysts have detected China’s actions -- described by Beijing as “professional and restrained” -- show the bigger nation has “harmful intentions,” given its ongoing anti-trespassing rule which encroaches on the West Philippine Sea.

Manila accused the Chinese Coast Guard of wielding knives, sticks and axe and stealing or damaging their equipment including guns and inflatable boats.

In previous confrontations Chinese forces used water cannon and military-grade lasers and collided with Filipino resupply vessels and their escorts.

“We have never, never in the history of the Philippines, yielded to any foreign power,” Marcos said to applause, while pledging to “continue to exercise our freedoms and rights in support of our national interest, in accordance with international law”.

But President Marcos stressed: “Our calm and peaceful disposition should not be mistaken for acquiescence.”

China’s dangerous tactic in territorial disputes

fire or missile strikes.

This nuance allows China to exert pressure and assert control while maintaining a veneer of restraint.

However, the use of such methods is a double-edged sword.

While they may reduce the immediate risk of large-scale conflict, they also introduce a volatile element of unpredictability.

In the heat of these confrontations, the potential for miscalculation is immense.

A single incident—such as a sailor losing a finger, or worse, an unintended fatality—could rapidly spiral out of control, igniting the very conflict these tactics aim to avoid.

The deaths of 20 Indian soldiers and several Chinese soldiers in the Galwan Valley in 2020 are a grim testament to this risk.

“
The path to lasting peace and stability in these contested regions lies not in the wielding of crude weapons but in the steadfast pursuit of diplomacy

Moreover, these encounters, though intended to be controlled shows of force, often teeter on the brink of escalation.

Each act of “jostling” or wielding of crude weapons is a step closer to breaking the fragile guardrails that currently prevent outright warfare.

The shooting incident in 2020 along the India-China border is a stark reminder of how quickly these “weak guardrails” can collapse, leading to a breakdown of even the minimal agreements that currently hold.

In light of these tensions, the call for diplomacy and adherence to interna-

tional law becomes even more urgent.

The international community, particularly key players like the United States, must push for a de-escalation and a return to diplomatic negotiations.

Clearer, more robust agreements that address the specifics of these non-conventional confrontations are needed.

Both China and its neighbors must commit to mechanisms that prevent these dangerous encounters from happening in the first place.

To this end, multilateral forums such as ASEAN, the United Nations, and other regional security dialogues should prioritize the establishment of conflict prevention and resolution mechanisms tailored to these unique and modern forms of conflict.

The focus should be on building trust, enhancing communication channels to prevent miscalculations, and creating binding agreements that specifically address the use of non-conventional weapons.

Furthermore, transparency and accountability must be strengthened.

Independent investigations into these incidents, coupled with public reporting, can help ensure that provocations are clearly documented and addressed in international forums.

This will help curb the temptation for any party to exploit ambiguity for strategic gain.

Ultimately, while the use of axes and knives may seem a restrained alternative to modern weaponry, it is a dangerous gamble that risks igniting the very conflicts it seeks to avoid.

The path to lasting peace and stability in these contested regions lies not in the wielding of crude weapons but in the steadfast pursuit of diplomacy, the rule of law, and mutual respect for sovereignty.

The international community must act now, with firmness and clarity, to steer these simmering tensions away from the brink and towards a sustainable resolution.

Trump -- who struggles in granular discussions of policy -- huddled with aides and vice presidential hopefuls at his Mar-a-Lago estate in Florida, where the emphasis was more on tone and broad substance than detail.

Trump would benefit by sticking to a script, highlighting Biden’s weaknesses on inflation and immigration and dialing down the bombast, said Nieman, the Binghamton analyst.

“It would disappoint his base, but it would go far to make inroads with suburban, college-educated women,” he told AFP. AFP

Western Visayas on high alert vs. Q fever cases

By Caloy Lozada

ILOILO City — Western Visayas has so far reported zero cases of Q fever, a potentially dangerous disease, according to a recent official statement from the Department of Agriculture-Western Visayas (DA-Western Visayas).

To maintain this status, the DA-Western Visayas is intensifying its animal border protocols, working closely with local government units (LGUs) and personnel from the Bureau of Animal Industry (BAI) to ensure that domestic ruminants are well-protected from the disease.

In a proactive move, the agency urges all stakeholders to stay vigilant and strictly adhere to biosecurity measures on their farms.

The DA advises immediate reporting of any sudden animal deaths to city or provincial veterinary offices or municipal agriculture offices. This allows for timely assessment, diagnosis, and control of potential outbreaks.

The Regional Animal Diseases Diagnostic Laboratory (RADDL) is fully equipped and ready to receive samples for diagnosing conditions such as haemonchosis, fascioliasis, caprine arthritis encephalitis (CAE), pneumonia due to weather changes, and diarrhea and bloat caused by dietary factors.

The DA-Western Visayas has declared a full-alert status to monitor and prevent the entry of Q fever into the region.

A variety of measures are in place to ensure that Western Visayas remains Q fever-free. According to the department's data, the region ranks fourth nationally in goat inventory, contributing 9.66% or 376,312 of the country's goats.

In the first quarter of 2024 alone, the region produced 1,483.2 metric tons of goat meat, accounting for 10.36% of the national production, as per data from the Philippine Statistics Authority.

The heightened vigilance follows an earlier report by the BAI of over 60 goats from the United States testing positive for Q fever at a government breeding station in Marinduque, Pampanga.

BI warns of bogus job offers posted online

By Vito Barcelo

THE Bureau of Immigration (BI) warned the public, particularly job seekers, from dealing with unknown individuals or companies on social media offering lucrative jobs abroad as these practices are illegal and result in human trafficking.

Immigration Commissioner Norman

Tansingco issued the warning upon learning of the recent interception of a Filipino woman at the Ninoy Aquino International Airport (NAIA) Terminal 1 who was stopped from leaving the country before she could board a Philippines Airlines Flight to Thailand.

The victim claimed to be a traveling tourist to visit a relative in Thailand, but later admitted that her true destination is Lebanon.

She eventually confessed that travel documents they presented were counterfeit, provided solely by the recruiter whom she had only communicated with via Facebook Messenger.

She admitted that the recruiter had instructed her to present herself as a tourist to mislead immigration officers during interviews.

Investigations revealed that the female victim had previously worked as an OFW in Lebanon and wanted to return to work using

illegal means.

Earlier, four Filipino women were repatriated from Korea who were all victims of illegal recruitment.

The victims arrived in the Philippines aboard a Jeju Air flight from South Korea after being detained for working illegally as entertainers without the necessary work visa in that region.

According to the victims, they were deceived into a scheme by a Filipino who instructed them to meet a Korean national to handle their documents processing.

Investigations revealed that the victims used the mobile phone app Telegram to communicate with their recruiters who offered them jobs as entertainers in a bar, promising a monthly salary of P80,000 until their 59-day tourist visas expired.



HONORING RAJAH SULAYMAN. Manila Mayor Honey Lacuna and Vice Mayor Yul Servo lead the flower offering to the statue of Rajah Sulayman in celebration of the 453rd anniversary of the founding of the city of Manila. **Norman Cruz**

IN BRIEF

Passengers urged to inspect gadgets at airports

THE Civil Aviation Authority of the Philippines (CAAP) is urging the public to thoroughly inspect their gadgets before plugging them into airport outlets following a burning charger incident at Dumaguete Airport on Sunday night.

In a report received by CAAP Area Center 7, a laptop emitted smoke while it was being charged at an electrical outlet in the departure area around 8:23 p.m. CAAP security personnel responded and used a fire extinguisher to put out the burning charger.

The fire was fully extinguished after around three minutes, but at least 160 air travelers were temporarily relocated to the ramp area due to a strong smoke smell in the area. The passengers were instructed to return to the pre-departure area at 8:40 p.m. and no flights have been affected.

The CAAP urges the public to be vigilant with their electronic gadgets at airports, ensuring they are properly inspected and in good condition. Electronics and gadgets like laptops, tablets, and cameras should also be placed in hand-carry baggage, and don't bring firearms, and live and non-live bullets.

This serves as a reminder from airport and airline officials to air travelers to make their trips less stressful. To prevent incidents involving unauthorized electronic devices, local airlines implements strict guidelines and conducts regular fire drill training for flight crew. **Joel Zurbano**

Bataan adopts online price monitoring system

THE Sangguniang Panlalawigan of Bataan presided by Vice Gov. Cris Garcia passed an ordinance establishing the Provincial Online Price Monitoring System in the province of Bataan.

It was passed during final reading on June 10, 2024.

The ordinance aims to ensure consumers have access to accurate and timely information about the prices of basic necessities and prime commodities. It also protects consumers from price manipulation and unfair trade practices.

The ordinance was sponsored by Board Member Jorge S. Estanislao. **Butch Gunio**

WORLD

Gunmen kill 19 in Russia's Dagestan

MOSCOW — Attacks on churches and synagogues in Russia's Dagestan region killed primarily police officers, officials said Monday, announcing a toll of 19 dead after violence that stoked fears over Islamist violence in the historically restive North Caucasus.

The assaults launched on Sunday come just three months after Islamic State group fighters killed more than 140 in a Moscow concert hall, the deadliest terror attack on Russia for almost 20 years.

Moscow said on Monday it had concluded an "anti-terrorist operation" and killed five of the assailants behind the coordi-

nated attacks on Sunday evening in the cities of Makhachkala and Derbent.

The incidents also had echoes of the kind of insurgent violence that marred the North Caucasus during the 1990s and 2000s.

Russia has been a target for Islamic State terror in recent years, with the fundamentalist group opposing Moscow's military support for Syrian leader Bashar al-Assad and claiming to have set-up a "franchise" in Russia's north Caucasus.

"According to preliminary data, 15 law enforcement officers were killed, as well as four civilians, including an Orthodox priest," Russia's Investigative Committee, which probes major crimes, said on Monday.

Five assailants had also been "liquidated", it added, though it was not clear how many had been involved in the attack.

The Russian Orthodox Church said its archpriest Nikolai Kotelnikov, had been "brutally killed" in an attack on a church in the city of Derbent.

The National Antiterrorism Committee, which responds to mass attacks and is tasked with foiling terror plots, said Monday morning it had wrapped up its rapid response operation.

"Following the neutralization of the threats to the lives and health of citizens, it was decided to end the anti-terrorist operation in Dagestan," at 08:15 am, it said in a statement. **AFP**



TERROR ATTACK. In this grab taken from a handout footage released by the National Antiterrorism Committee on Monday, Russia's FSB security service officers conduct an anti-terrorist operation in Dagestan. An operation against gunmen who attacked churches and a synagogue in Russia's Muslim-dominated Dagestan region killed at least 19 people is now over, the national anti-terrorism agency said. **AFP**

Turkey flags faulty wires in wildfire, 15 dead

DIYARBAKIR, Turkey — The death toll from a massive wildfire that ripped through Turkey's mainly Kurdish southeast last week has risen to 15, hospital sources said on Monday as experts pointed to faulty wiring as a possible cause.

The blaze, which broke out on Thursday between the cities of Diyarbakir and Mardin, killed 12 people outright and left five fight-

ing for their lives.

Three succumbed to their injuries on Sunday, the Anadolu state news agency said.

Hospital sources confirmed the toll on Monday, saying two people remained in intensive care.

Hundreds of animals also perished in the blaze that roared across the dry landscape.

The government said "stubble burning" was the cause but the

Diyarbakir branch of Chambers of Turkish Architects and Engineers ruled that out and pointed to faulty electric cables as the likely trigger.

"The fire could have been caused by the power cables," it said in a report released late on Sunday, indicating there was "no stubble" in the area and saying the electric wires in the area were in a state of disrepair. **AFP**

IN BRIEF

'Parasites, defaced clothes in N. Korea balloons'

SEOUL — Parasites from human feces and defaced Western clothing were found in the bags of garbage carried by North Korean balloons into the South, Seoul said Monday.

Pyongyang has sent more than a thousand trash-carrying balloons into the South in recent weeks, in retaliation for leaflets sent northwards by activists opposed to North Korean leader Kim Jong Un.

An analysis of the contents of some 70 of the balloons found that they contained soil in which "numerous parasites, such as roundworms, whipworms and threadworms" were detected, South Korea's ministry of unification said in a statement.

This is likely because human feces was used in the soil instead of chemical fertilizers, it added.

It said there was "no risk of land pollution (or) infectious diseases" from the balloons, as the volume of soil sent was relatively low. **AFP**

Taiwan president seeks to overturn reform

TAIPEI — Taiwan's President Lai Ching-te signed into law on Monday a controversial reform expanding parliament's powers, but vowed to seek a ruling from the island's top court to try to overturn it.

Proponents of the expansion say it is needed to curb corruption, but critics fear the laws could weaken self-ruled Taiwan's democracy against the influence of China -- which claims the island as part of its territory.

Taiwan's president is part of the Democratic Progressive Party (DPP), which advocates for the island's sovereignty. But it lost the parliamentary majority in January elections, spelling trouble for his administration.

The reform bills passed last month had sparked massive protests on the island.

"The parliament should reform, but it should not arbitrarily expand its powers. The way to reform should be legal and constitutional," Lai said Monday.

"Today, I have made the decision to petition for a constitutional interpretation... This is to be responsible to the country and to history, and to live up to the trust of the people," he told journalists. **AFP**



Republic of the Philippines
Department of Transportation
CIVIL AERONAUTICS BOARD
OLD MIA ROAD, PASAY CITY,
Metro Manila



IN RE: APPLICATION FOR ORIGINAL AUTHORITY TO OPERATE AS AN INTERNATIONAL AIRFREIGHT FORWARDER

CAB CASE NO. EP-24-4015-ACFD-062024-0978-0

DP WORLD PHILIPPINES LOGISTICS, INC.,
Applicant.

x-----x

NOTICE OF PRELIMINARY HEARING

Pursuant to the provision of Republic Act No. 776, as amended, Notice is hereby given that DP WORLD PHILIPPINES LOGISTICS, INC. has applied with the Civil Aeronautics Board (CAB) an application for original authority to operate as International Airfreight Forwarder. The application shall be given due course by this Board within three (3) working days from completion of all requirements.

Parties opposed to the granting of this application must file their written opposition supported by documentary evidence within ten (10) working days from publication hereof, furnishing a copy of the same to the applicant, and if any so desire, appear before the Board. Failure on the part of any interested party to register its opposition on time shall be construed as a waiver of its right to be heard. Thereupon, the Board shall act upon the application on the basis of the records and documentary evidence presented by the parties, unless the Board deems it necessary to receive additional documentary and/or testimonial evidence.

Let a copy of the application and this Notice be posted in CAB Bulletin Board beginning this day.

June 24, 2024
Pasay City, Philippines



ATTY. MARIA CECILIA C. PAGUIRIGAN
Chief, Air Carrier Accounts and Field Audit Division

cc: **MS. GRACE AYO-GARDE**
Treasurer
DP WORLD PHILIPPINES LOGISTICS, INC.
11th Floor, 8 Rockwell, Hidalgo Drive
Rockwell Center, Makati City

(MS-JUNE 25/JUL 2 & 9, 2024)

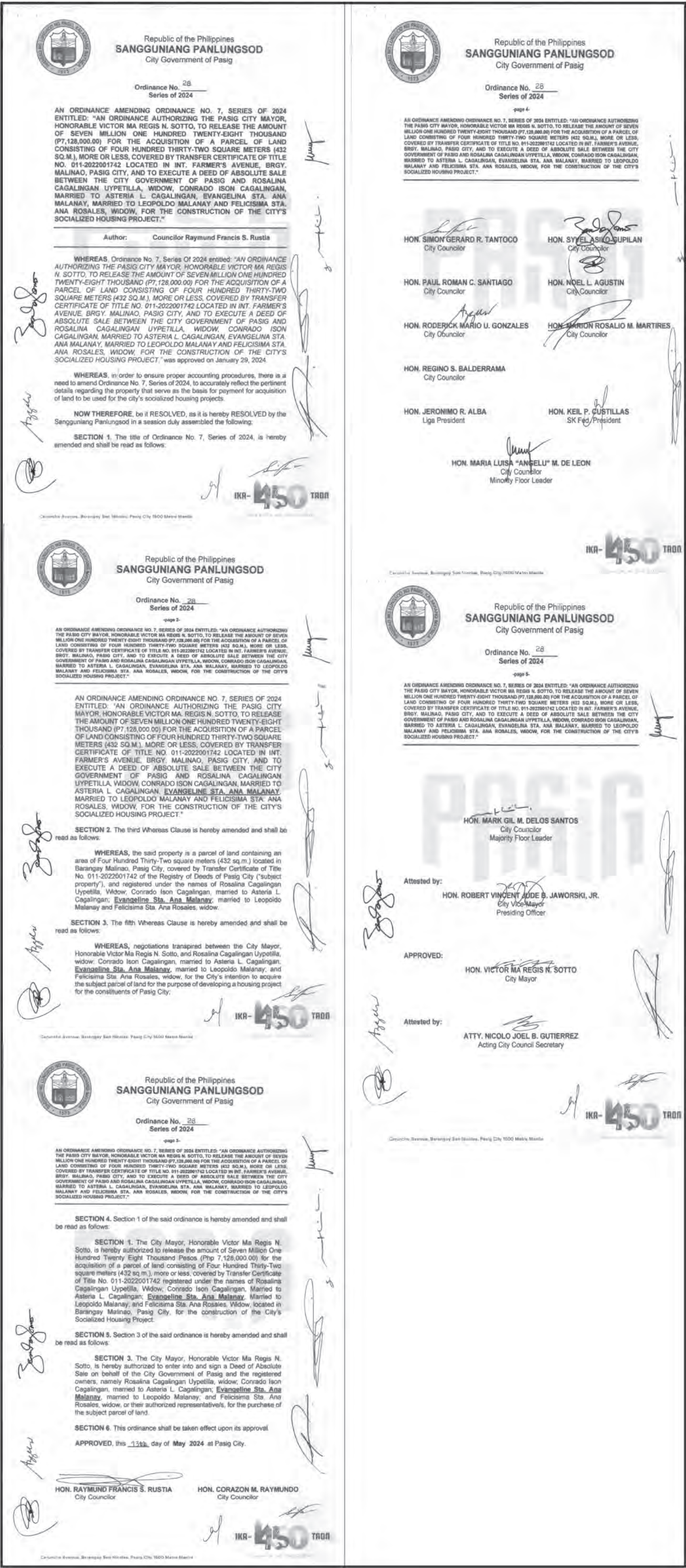
RUNRIO Pride Run 2024 for LGBTQIA+ a rousing success

BingoPlus Foundation also donated P500,000 to LoveYourselfPH in raising awareness about HIV prevention as part of its advocacy in making healthcare more accessible to various communities.

Cavin Vedal ruled the 5K with his time of 16 minutes and 47 seconds, followed by

"We encourage everybody to get into

Expecting a charge from Sinfuego and other contenders, including one-armed golfer Necky Tortosa, who made a 108, Gotiong vowed to do better on Tuesday but stressed the need to minimize mistakes.





PHILIPPINE Olympic Committee (POC) President Abraham “Bambol” Tolentino and Chef de Mission Jonvic Remulla do the rounds of the facilities with the first batch of athletes and coaches at the Metz training camp.

Filipino athletes begin training in Metz—POC chief Tolentino

WORK began in earnest at the Team Philippines training camp in Metz on Sunday with Philippine Olympic Committee (POC) president Abraham “Bambol” Tolentino and Chef de Mission Jonvic Remulla leading the rounds at the all-in facility where the Olympics-bound Filipino athletes will get in harness for a month.

“It’s all systems go here at La Moselle,” said Tolentino, adding “and the morale of the team is very high.” This marks the first time that the POC is conducting a training camp for Olympic athletes a month before the competition—the Paris Olympics starts July 26. “The first batch of athletes that

flew in with us here last Saturday morning are amazed with the facility and are eager to wind up their training for their respective events for the Olympics,” added Tolentino, who met up with Team Philippines with Remulla in Metz also on Sunday. “The athletes are excited and enthusiastic about this training camp the

main objective of which is to make sure our athletes are in top shape for the competitions,” Remulla said. The first batch of the 15 Filipino athletes who are so far qualified for the Olympics included weightlifters Vanessa Sarno and Elreen Ando, boxers Aira Villegas, Hergie Bacayadan, Carlo Paalam, and Nesthy Petecio, rower Joanie Delgaco and weightlifter John Februar Ceniza. They are also accompanied by secretary-general Atty. Wharton Chan, the athletes coaches and trainers, and a lean POC staff who set the facility ahead of the team’s arrival will be in France for the entire duration of the Games that that will end August 11. Expected to arrive in Metz from different origins in the next few days

are boxer Eumir Felix Marcial, fencer Samantha Catantan, and gymnasts Carlos Yulo, Emma Malabuyo and Levi Ruivivar. Team Philippines to Paris, according to Tolentino, would breach the 20-athlete mark with more qualifiers expected in athletics, golf, and swimming—the sport’s international federations will announce the official qualifiers for the Olympics this week. “The Paris campaign is now in full throttle,” said Tolentino, who, during his first watch at the POC in Tokyo 2020, emerged the country’s first Olympics gold medalist, weightlifter Hidilyn Diaz-Naranjo, and the best finish ever by the country in the Games with Paalam and Petecio’s silvers and Marcial’s bronze medal.

Army men dominate swimming on first day of ROTC Games-Mindanao

ZAMBOANGA City—As expected, the Philippine Army grabbed nine golds to dominate the first day of the medal-rich swimming competitions at the Joaquin F. Enriquez Memorial Sports Complex Aquatic Center. Ronnie Tayom, Reymond Pelisan, Herjamie Guiao, Jellie S. Somera, and Jovaira Valle cornered two golds apiece in their respective events to lead the Army cadets’ onslaught with still plenty of time to spare. Wendelen Sangcom was the lone from the dreaded army squad to snare a lone gold on a rather good humid day. Tayom ruled the men’s 200-m individual medley in 3:07.02 as well as the men’s 50-m backstroke in 37.04, while Pelisan won the men’s 100-m freestyle in 1:09.84 and Guiao easily romped 37.73 to win the men’s 50-m butterfly and the men’s 200-m breaststroke in 3:58.83. Somera, on the other hand, proved too much in the women’s 100-m freestyle in 1:22.38 and the women’s 50-m backstroke in 41.55, while Valle made her presence felt in the women’s 200-m individual medley in 4:13.62 and the women’s 50-m butterfly 45.30. The Air Force cadets likewise settled with six golds courtesy of John Austin Hampac in the men’s 100-m freestyle in 59.33 and in the men’s 50-m butterfly in 28.06. Teammate Daniella Melburn followed suit with two golds from women’s 100-m freestyle (1:37.76) and women’s 50-m butterfly (42.75). But teammates Christian Adrino and Rashiden Minor had only one gilt from the men’s 50-m backstroke (51.78) and 200-m backstroke (3:59.24), respectively. The Navy Sailors brought home three golds all from Haji Al-Jhaes in men’s 50-m butterfly (31.43) and men’s 200-m individual medley (2:59.90) while his third gold came from the men’s 50-m backstroke to become the winningest cadet-athlete. Exciting actions continue today as arnis and chess will be played at the Zamboanga State College of Marine Sciences and Technology Gymnasium, while athletics and swimming will be held at the Joaquin F. Enriquez Memorial Sports Complex.

Boxer Paalam grateful for Go’s financial support

By Peter Atencio

CARLO Paalam, who recently moved up to a higher weight class, expressed gratitude for the financial assistance he received before traveling to Paris, France. Receiving a check for P500,000 in support of his campaign for the upcoming Paris Olympics was a significant blessing for him. “Safe kami sa biyahe. Sobrang saya, kasama kong ang team ko,” said the 25-year-old Paalam, after joining nine of the 15 Paris Olympics-bound athletes to personally receive the financial assistance provided by Sen. Christopher “Bong” Go, chairman of the Senate Committee on Sports. Paalam, who has returned to action after his second World Boxing Olympic Qualification, earned his ticket to the Paris Games two months ago by winning a unanimous decision over India’s Sachin Sachin in the semifinals of the men’s 57kg division. This victory followed his success in all five bouts during the second World Qualification Tournament in Bangkok, Thailand. “Makakatulong ito, Maiiwan dito ang pamilya ko,” added Paalam, referring to his young daughter Celest and his wife Earl Shane.

Hailing from Cagayan de Oro, Paalam is coming off an injury that forced him to withdraw in the Round of 16 at the World Qualification Tournament last March. However, he is expected to make a strong comeback as the first batch of the 15 Filipino athletes has begun training at the Metz camp in La Moselle. The athletes who have qualified for the Olympics and are now in Paris include weightlifters Vanessa Sarno and Elreen Ando, boxers Aira Villegas, Hergie Bacayadan, Carlo Paalam, and Nesthy Petecio, rower Joanie Delgaco, and weightlifter John Februar Ceniza. In his capacity as chairman of the Senate Committee on Sports, Sen. Go personally distributed checks to the members of the Philippine contingent, totaling around P7.5 million.

Vermosa Green Run will help raise young athletes in Cavite

THE Green Run at Vermosa has taken its popular multi-category run to the next level this year. Besides providing an opportunity for fun runners, running enthusiasts, serious runners and elite athletes the chance to hit the trails for recreation and training, this year’s run is focused on giving assistance to young runners from Cavite who want to pursue their dreams of becoming national track athletes. On June 14, Ayala Land Estates, Inc. welcomed Takbo Kabitenyo, an organization in Cavite dedicated to nurturing the talents of its aspiring athletes who have the ambition and potential to become national athletes. Ayala Land, through its Ayala Vermosa Sports Hub in Imus, opened its doors to the running youngsters of Cavite. Ayala Land representatives led by Chrissy Roa, Group Head of Marketing and Communications for Ayala Land Estates, donated 30 Green Run race kits and products from Merrell, a brand dedicated to running, to the Cavite running organization at Vermosa. The Takbo Kabitenyo group will also receive freebies and gifts from all Vermosa Green Run sponsors



All is set for the Vermosa Green Run with partner organization Takbo Kabitenyo.

at the Run that will gun off on Sunday, June 30. “We are committed to providing these aspiring athletes with the training, support and opportunities they need to achieve their dreams and represent our community on a national level,” said Ms. Roa. The Ayala Vermosa Sports Hub, envisioned to be the preferred venue for national and international sports events in the Philippines, will be a perfect training camp for the young Cavite athletes. Noel Diaz, Takbo Kabitenyo presi-

dent, expressed his gratitude for the support - “We are deeply grateful to Ayala Land Estates Inc. and Vermosa for choosing Takbo Kabitenyo as one of the beneficiaries of the 2024 The Green Run. The exposure to this prestigious event will hopefully inspire our young runners to elevate their aspirations and work even harder towards excellence in their chosen sports,” he said. Ayala Land Estates has launched another running initiative alongside The Green Run this year called the Ayala Vermosa Running Club. It has weekly activities for its members and classes conducted by Ayala Vermosa Sports Hub coaches. The environment-themed run is also supporting the Pawssion Project and Haribon Foundation on its third year. Fueled by its 2024 theme of “Go Greener, Get Leaner, Give Back: Run Towards a Brighter Future”, The Green Run 2024 is supported by Avida Sentria Storeys, Kremil-S, Diatabs, Merrell, Pocari Sweat, Park Access, Chris Sports, Fitbar, Naturals, Healthway Medical Network, Fuwa Fuwa, Nutrition Depot, and Oishi.

BingoPlus, ArenaPlus celebrate successful PBA PH Cup

BINGOPLUS, the leading entertainment platform in the country, alongside its 24/7 sports gaming app, ArenaPlus, celebrates the successful conclusion of the 48th season of the PBA Philippine Cup with the Philippine Basketball Association (PBA). As the official sports entertainment gateway and the official bingo entertainment partner of the PBA, BingoPlus is committed to delivering an enjoyable and engaging PBA experience for all Filipinos, anytime and anywhere. This season’s finals featured an exciting matchup between the San Miguel Beermen and the Meralco Bolts, rekindling a historic rivalry

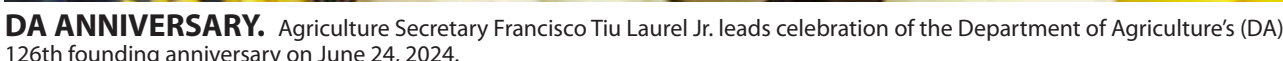
dating back to the Manila Industrial and Commercial Athletic Association (MICA) days. The Meralco Bolts emerged victorious with a 4-2 series win over the San Miguel Beermen, clinching the championship with an 80-78 victory in Game 6 on Sunday, June 16, at the Araneta Coliseum. Cris Newsome, a standout since joining the Bolts in 2015, led the way with 15 points, five rebounds, and four assists, earning the title of PBA Philippine Cup Finals MVP. In an exclusive interview during the finals press conference, Newsome reflected on the significance of the championship, noting that his first PBA matchup was against the



The Meralco Bolts whoop it up after their 4-2 championship victory over San Miguel Beermen.

same team he now faced in his first championship finals. “What makes it special is it is the first one in the Meralco franchise history.

It shows that we’ve been working really hard as an organization to continue to improve and be better every single year,” Newsome shared.



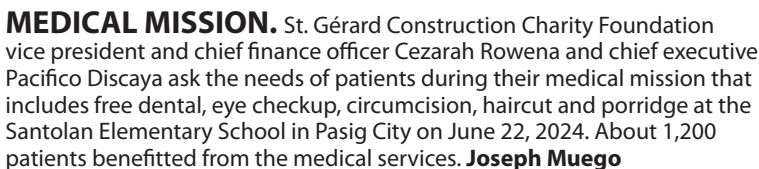
“The company is addressing the incident and has implemented its response protocols and deployed enhanced security measures to further protect the company’s and its subsidiaries’ data against threats. The company has also launched its investigation on the matter to understand the scope of this incident, and is currently working with the relevant authorities and experts in its investigation.” the company said.

HCl of Vietnam

Indonesia and Vietnam, despite being lower-middle-

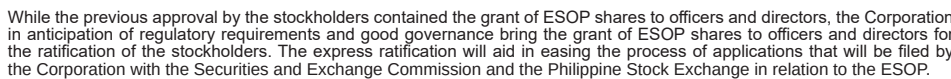
“The Philippines urgently needs to address nutrition and early childhood education issues among young children, as these affect their future skill formation and productivity,” the World Bank said.

B2



The P27.10 billion CCLEX, which began commercial operations on April 30, 2022, is the first expressway in southern Philippines. It connects Mactan Island through Cordova town to mainland Cebu through the South Road Properties.

He said the company is selling a 45-percent equity in Cebu Cordova Link Expressway Corp. (CCLEC),



REPUBLIC OF THE PHILIPPINES
NATIONAL CAPITAL JUDICIAL REGION
REGIONAL TRIAL COURT
BRANCH 98, QUEZON CITY
rtc1qzn098@judiciary.gov.ph
Contact No. (02)8518-0393

SPouses Wilfredo R. Lua & Victoriana L. Lua

Plaintiffs,

-versus-

R-QZN-23-07694-CV
For: Recovery of Possession with Damages

SPS. AUGUSTINE R. PAGUIRIGAN & MA. ANACLETA RACHELLE C. PAGUIRIGAN, SPS. JOSELITO A. PANGANIBAN & EMMA B. PANGANIBAN, SPS. FRANKLIN B. MENDOZA & LOLITA BOO MENDOZA & ALL PERSONS CLAIMING RIGHTS UNDER THEM.

Defendants.

SUMMONS

Petitioner filed a Complaint for Recovery of Possession and Damages before this Court on 23 August 2023 against defendants Sps. Augustine R. Paguirigan & Ma. Anacleta Rachelle C. Paguirigan, Sps. Josecito A. Panganiban & Emma B. Panganiban, Sps. Franklin B. Mendoza & Lolita Boo Mendoza & all persons claiming rights under them;

Plaintiffs own a property at Block 16, Piedmont St., Barangay East Fairview, Quezon City consisting of Four Hundred (400) square meters more or less and covered by Transfer Certificate of Title No. 004-2017002414. Its assessed value, including the current structure is around One Million One Hundred Thirty Thousand Pesos (Php1,130,000.00), more or less;

Last 01 June 2015 defendants Sps. Paguirigan secured a loan in the amount of Four Million Pesos (Php4,000,000.00) from the plaintiffs. This was covered by a Deed of Real Estate Mortgage;

Plaintiffs had the mortgage annotated on the previous title of defendants Sps. Paguirigan;

When defendants Sps. Paguirigan failed to comply with their obligations under the mortgage contract, plaintiffs foreclosed the property subject thereof and acquired it, together with all the improvements thereon, in a public sale, for a total amount of Five Million One Hundred Twenty-Six Thousand Three Hundred Seventy Two Pesos and Seventy Four Centavos (Php 5,126,372.74);

Defendants Sps. Paguirigan also built structure thereon consisting of two-unit apartments without any permission from the plaintiffs;

Thereafter, plaintiffs learned that defendants Sps. Paguirigan built this structure without the required building permit from the city government. Worse, defendant Sps. Paguirigan, without the knowledge of plaintiffs, had sold the said units to the other defendants who then occupied the property despite the proscription in the above-mentioned Deed of Real Estate Mortgage;

On 26 April 2017, plaintiffs filed a petition for the issuance of a writ of possession but was dismissed for being an improper action. Subsequently, a petition for recovery of possession against defendants was also filed but plaintiffs decided to withdraw the same due to some technicalities. Currently, there are no more pending cases filed against defendants;

At the time of mortgage, plaintiffs never knew about, or met the other defendants, nor did defendants Sps. Paguirigan reveal their transactions to the plaintiffs;

Aside from visiting the property, and as part of their due diligence, plaintiffs also checked the title of defendant Sps. Paguirigan with the Register of Deeds and found no encumbrances thereon from any other buyer or mortgagee. It appears that defendants Sps. Paguirigan acquired the property from a certain Josefina Salonga Guevarra as evidenced by a Deed of Absolute Sale dated 06 February 2015.

Being a mortgagor and builder in bad faith, defendant Sps. Paguirigan should be held accountable for their acts under Article 448 of the Civil Code of the Philippines;

Defendants Sps. Panganiban and Sps. Mendoza are equally in bad faith as the mortgage contract between plaintiffs and defendants Sps. Paguirigan was annotated on the latter's title as early as 01 June 2015. Had they conducted due diligence, they would have known that the subject property was encumbered and should have cancelled whatever transaction they had with defendants Sps. Paguirigan. Verily, by failing to exercise due diligence, defendant Sps. Panganiban and Sps. Mendoza cannot claim good faith;

On 08 September 2023, an Order was issued finding the Complaint to be sufficient in form and in substance and directed the Officer-in-Charge Almeria P. Belinario to issue the corresponding Summons to all defendants with a copy of the Complaint appended therewith including its attachments and directing the defendants to file a proper Answer in accordance with the 2019 Amendments to the Rules of Civil Procedure under Supreme Court Administrative Circular No. 19-10-SC;

Summons were duly served upon defendants Sps Panganiban, Sps. Mendoza, and Augustine R. Paguirigan;

However, defendant Ma. Anacleta Rachelle C. Paguirigan's could not be served personally or through substituted service considering that she is not residing anymore in her last known address as reflected in the records of this case;

Plaintiffs exerted diligent effort to find defendant Ma. Anacleta Rachelle C. Paguirigan's whereabouts, but to no avail. Hence, they sought for the service of Summons and all court processes to defendant Ma. Anacleta Rachelle C. Paguirigan through publication;

NOW THEREFORE, defendant Ma. Anacleta Rachelle C. Paguirigan's, whose last known address on record is **NO. 43 WINSTON STREET, BARANGAY EAST FAIRVIEW, QUEZON CITY**, is hereby SUMMONED and REQUIRED to enter her appearance and file her Answer to the Complaint in the above-entitled case within a period of sixty (60) days after the last day of publication hereof. Otherwise, the Court may grant the reliefs prayed for by the plaintiffs based on the evidence presented and offered.

Let this summons be published twice (2) in the successive issues of a newspaper of general circulation in the Philippines at the expense of the plaintiffs, to be selected by raffie.

GIVEN UNDER MY HAND AND SEAL OF THIS COURT this 12th day of April 2024 in Quezon City, Philippines.

(Sgd.) MARIA CRISTINA D.R. ROSARIO-OSOTEO
Acting Presiding Judge¹

COPY FURNISHED:

ATTY. PETER ANTHONY RAFANAN
Counsel for the Plaintiff
Unit 112-A Mezzanine Floor, Limketkai Building, Ortigas Avenue, Greenhills, San Juan City
rafaanan_peter@yahoo.com

ATTY. MARIO ROSARIO UY GALIT
Counsel for Defendants Spouses Panganiban and Mendoza
NRC Law Office
Level 1 EMRSI-005 Expansion Bldg., Quirino Highway, Barangay Pasong Putik, Novaliches, Quezon City, 1118

SPouses Wilfredo R. Lua & Victoriana L. Lua
Plaintiffs
No. 245 Banawe Street, Barangay Manresa, Quezon City

SPouses Augustine R. Paguirigan & Ma. Anacleta Rachelle C. Paguirigan
Defendants
Lot 13-A, Block 16, Piedmont Street, Barangay East Fairview, Quezon City

SPouses Josecito A. Panganiban & Emma B. Panganiban
Defendants
Lot 13-A, Block 16, Piedmont Street, Barangay East Fairview, Quezon City

SPouses Franklin B. Mendoza & Lolita Boo Mendoza
Defendants
Lot 13-A, Block 16, Piedmont Street, Barangay East Fairview, Quezon City

1Administrative Order No. 182-2022 designating Hon. Maria Cristina D.R. Rosario-Osoteo as Acting Presiding Judge (fulltime), signed on July 8, 2022

REPUBLIC OF THE PHILIPPINES
NATIONAL CAPITAL JUDICIAL REGION
REGIONAL TRIAL COURT
BRANCH 98, QUEZON CITY

SPouses Wilfredo R. Lua & Victoriana L. Lua

Plaintiffs,

-versus-

Civil Case No.: R-QZN-23-07694-CV
For: Recovery of Possession and Damages

SPS. AUGUSTINE R. PAGUIRIGAN & MA. ANACLETA RACHELLE C. PAGUIRIGAN, SPS. JOSELITO A. PANGANIBAN & EMMA B. PANGANIBAN, SPS. FRANKLIN B. MENDOZA & LOLITA BOO MENDOZA & ALL PERSONS CLAIMING RIGHTS UNDER THEM.

Defendants.

JUDICIAL AFFIDAVIT

I, **WILFREDO R. LUA**, of legal age, Filipino, with postal address at #245 Banawe St. Brgy. Manresa, Quezon City, after having been duly sworn in accordance with law, with full knowledge that I may be charged with perjury or false testimony, hereby depose and state before Atty. Peter Anthony V. Rafanan in his office at Unit 112-A Mezzanine Floor, Limketkai Building, Ortigas Avenue, Greenhills, San Juan City, the following to constitute as my direct testimony in this case:

OFFER OF TESTIMONY

Atty. Rafanan, who conducted the examination, is presenting the witness and offering his testimony to prove the material allegations in the complaint, specifically the fact that: 1) Defendants-spouses Augustine Paguirigan and Anacleta Rachelle Paguirigan mortgaged to the plaintiffs the property subject of the instant case sometime in June 2015; 2) Said defendants did not comply with their obligations under the mortgage contract; thus, the subject property was foreclosed and plaintiffs acquired it in a public sale; 3) Said defendants did not redeem the property from the plaintiffs, thus, its title was consolidated in the names of the plaintiffs; 4) Although they violated the mortgage contract and eventually lost the property subject thereof, said defendants still decided to build a structure thereon without the necessary permits; 5) Defendants Paguirigans sold the said property to the other defendants without the plaintiffs knowledge and, 6) Other related circumstances. The witness will also identify relevant document in support of his testimony

EXAMINATION

1Q. Mr. Witness, why did you execute this judicial affidavit?
A. I executed this affidavit to be used as my testimony in this case, Sir.

2Q. How are you related to plaintiff Wilfredo R. Lua?
A. I am that person, sir.

3Q. How about the other plaintiff, Victoriana L. Lua, do you know her?
A. Yes, sir. She is my spouse.

4Q. Do you know the defendants-spouses Augustine Paguirigan and Anacleta Rachelle Paguirigan?
A. Yes, sir.

5Q. Why do you know them?
A. Because they mortgaged a real property to us sometime in June 2015, sir.

6Q. How about defendants-spouses Josecito Panganiban and Emma Panganiban?
A. I only know them because they are among the current occupants of our property which is the subject of this case, sir.

7Q. How about defendants-spouses Franklin Mendoza and Lolita Boo Mendoza?
A. They are also among the occupants of our property, sir, but I do not know them personally.

8Q. Earlier, you said that defendants Paguirigans mortgaged a property to you sometime in June 2015. Would you describe this property?
A. It is a parcel of land consisting of around four hundred (400) square meters located at Block 16, Piedmont St., Barangay East Fairview Quezon City, sir.

9Q. Who is the owner of this property now?
A. We are, sir.

10Q. Do you have any proof about that?
A. Yes, sir, we have the title in our names which is attached here and marked as **Exhibit "A"**.

11Q. How much is the assessed value of this property?
A. The lot and the current structure consisting of two apartment units have a total assessed value of around One Million One Hundred Thirty Thousand Pesos (php1,130,000.00), more or less, sir.

12Q. Can you show copies of their tax declarations?
A. The tax declarations for the lot and one of the two apartment units are hereto attached as **Exhibits "B" to "B-1"**, sir. The second unit has no tax declaration yet, but its assessed value is more or less the same as that of the first unit.

13Q. Who is currently in possession of this property?
A. The defendants, sir.

14Q. Earlier, you said that the property was mortgage to you by defendants Paguirigans. How much (loan) did they take on that property?
A. Four million pesos (Php4,000,000.00), sir.

15Q. Do you have any proof of that mortgage?
A. Yes, sir. A copy of our mortgage contract is hereto attached and marked as **Exhibit "C"**.

16Q. After you executed that mortgage, what happened next, if any?
A. We have the mortgage annotated on the title of said defendants on June 1, 2015, sir.

17Q. Do you have any proof about that?
A. Yes, sir. A certified true copy of their previous title is attached here and marked as **Exhibit "D"**, while the annotation is marked **Exhibit "D-1"**.

18Q. What else happened after the execution of the mortgage contract, if any?
A. Defendants Paguirigans did not pay their monthly dues,² Sir.

19Q. So what did you do, if any, when they violated their obligations under your mortgage contract.
A. We were constrained to foreclose the property subject of the mortgage, Sir, and we eventually acquired it in a public sale.

20Q. For how much did you acquire it in that public sale?
A. Five Million One Hundred Twenty Six Thousand Three Hundred Seventy Two Pesos and Seventy Four Centavos (Php5,126,372.74), sir.

21Q. Do you have any proof to support that?
A. Yes, sir. A copy of the *Certificate of Sale* issued by the court sheriff is attached here and marked as **Exhibit "E"**.

22Q. After the court sheriff issued the certificate of sale, what happened next?
A. Defendants Paguirigans did not redeem the property within one (1) year from the registration of the sale so we had the title of the property transferred in our names, as shown in our Exhibit "A", sir.

23Q. What is the status of the property now?
A. It is still under the control and possession of the defendants, sir.

24Q. How did it happen considering that it is already in your name?
A. Because defendants Paguirigans, despite fully knowing that they could lose the property when they mortgaged it to us as, in fact, they eventually lost it, built a structure thereon without our permission, sir.

25Q. And what happened to this structure?
A. It was sold by defendants Paguirigans to the four other defendants, again without our knowledge or permission, sir.

26Q. Why should the Paguirigans have to ask your permission selling the property? In
A. Because it is stated in our mortgage contract (*Exh. "C"*), Specifically in paragraph 10 thereof, that they may not sell the property or any improvement, thereon during the term of the mortgage without our written permission, Sir.

27Q. You earlier said that the Paguirigans built a structure on the subject property without your knowledge or permission. When did they build it?
A. I do not know, sir. We checked with the building official of Quezon City and discovered that the Paguirigans, their company, and even the other defendants did not secure the necessary building permit when the structure was erected.

28Q. Do you have any proof about that?
A. Yes, sir. We have certifications to this effect from the city building official which are attached here and marked as **Exhibits "F" to "F-1"**.

29Q. What action, if any, did you already take against the defendants, specifically the Paguirigans, for what they did?
A. We actually filed a petition for writ of possession before, sir, but it was dismissed on technicality because it was not the proper legal action to take under the circumstances. We subsequently filed a complaint for recovery of possession before

the Metropolitan Trial Court, but we decided to withdraw it even before the pre-trial could start due to some technicalities, sir.

30Q. Can you show copies of the court's final issuances in those cases for our reference?
A. Yes, sir. They are attached here and marked as **Exhibits "G" to "G-1"**.

31 Q. Is there any other pending case between you and the defendants in any court?
A. None, sir.

32Q. By the way, when you and the Paguirigans executed the mortgage contract in June 2015, did you already know the other defendants in this case?
A. No, sir. The Paguirigans did not mention them or their transactions to us and, also, there was no structure or any ongoing construction at the property at that time.
33Q. How did you know it?
A. Because before we executed the mortgage contract, we visited the property as part of our due diligence and Mr. Paguirigan pointed to us the lot which was the subject of the mortgage, sir.

34Q. Aside from visiting the property, what else did you do as part of your due diligence?
A. We checked the title of the Paguirigans with the Register of Deeds and found no encumbrance thereon from any other buyer or mortgagee. What we found out was that the property was acquired by them from a certain Josefina Salonga Guevarra.

35Q. Do you have a copy of the deed of convenience between the Paguirigans and Ms. Guevarra?
A. Yes, sir. They executed a *Deed of Absolute Sale* dated February 6, 2015, a copy of which is attached here and marked as **Exhibit "L"**.

36Q. What else did you do, if any?
A. We asked from the Paguirigans to show us the owner's copy of the their title, and they admitted that it was then under mortgage with Megaland.

37Q. So what did you do when you learned about that information?
A. We checked with Megaland and confirmed that, indeed, the owner's copy of the title was with it, so we required the Paguirigans to clear first their obligation with Megaland, which they did. That was how we were able to take hold of the owner's copy of the old title.

38Q. When did you come to know about the other defendants?
A. We only learned about them and their transactions with defendants Paguirigan when they intervened in the petition for writ of possession that I filed, sir.

39Q. Did not they cause the annotation of their alleged interest on the title of the Paguirigans?
A. They did not, sir. They only did it on **July 3, 2017** when the title was ready in our names, and this was more than two years after we had the mortgage contract annotated on the title of the Paguirigans on **June 1, 2015**.

40Q. What does that signify?
A. That means that they were not buyers in good faith because they did not conduct due diligence when they transacted with the Paguirigans, sir. Had they done it, they would have known as early as June 1, 2015 that the subject property was already mortgaged to us, as annotated on its title.

41Q. What did you do, if any, before you filed this case?
A. We sent demand letters to the defendants, sir, but to no avail.

42Q. Do you have any proof about that?
A. Copies of our last demand letters are hereto attached and marked as **Exhibits "H" to "J-1"**, sir.

43Q. What else did you do, if any?
A. We also brought the matter to the barangay, but nothing happened, sir.

44Q. What is your proof about that?
A. The barangay certification, sir, a copy of which is hereto attached and marked as **Exhibit "K"**.

45Q. What reliefs are you asking from the Honorable Court?
A. First, I would like to request the Honorable Court to order the defendants to vacate our property and turn it over to us, sir.

46Q. What else?
A. Because of what the defendants did, I and my wife suffered years of sleepless nights, wounded feelings and mental anxiety so they should be ordered to pay us moral, nominal and exemplary damages, as prayed for in our complaint, and which I fully adopt here, sir.

47Q. What else, if any?
A. Because of the defendants' refusal to vacate and turnover the subject property to us, we were constrained to engage the services of a lawyer to litigate. So we are asking for an award of attorney's fees, as also prayed for in our complaint, sir.

48Q. What else?
A. Nothing more at this point, sir.

IN WITNESS WHEREOF, I have hereunto affixed my signature this **17 AUGUST 2023** in San Juan City.

(Sgd.) **WILFREDO R. LUA**
Affiant

SUBSCRIBED AND SWORN TO before me in San Juan City, this **17 AUGUST 2023**. I further certify that I have personally examined the affiant and am satisfied that he voluntarily and knowingly executed the foregoing judicial affidavit.

(Sgd.) **MA. CRISTIE GIESEL H. MASALANG**
Notary Public for and in the Cities of Pasig and San Juan and in the Municipality of Pateros, Metro Manila
Until 31 December 2024
Appointment No. 239 (2023-2024)
PTR No. 1665568 / San Juan / 1/3/2023
Roll of Attorneys No. 80600
Admitted to the Philippine Bar on 05/20/2022
Room 110 Marca Leon Limketkai Bldg., Ortigas Avenue
Greenhills, San Juan City, Metro Manila 1503

Doc. No. 392;
Page No. 80;
Book No. 04;
Series of 2023

ATTESTATION

I, Peter Anthony V. Rafanan, of legal age, with postal address at Unit 112-A Mezzanine Floor, Limketkai Building, Ortigas Avenue, Greenhills, San Juan City, hereby attest under oath that:

1. I am the one who examined the afore-named witness;
2. I faithfully recorded or caused to be recorded the questions I asked and the corresponding answers that the witness gave, and neither he nor any other person then present or assisting him coached him regarding his answers.

IN WITNESS WHEREOF, I have hereunto affixed my signature this **17 AUGUST 2023** in San Juan City.

(Sgd.) **PETER ANTHONY V. RAFANAN**

SUBSCRIBED AND SWORN TO before me in San Juan City, this **17 AUGUST 2023**. I further certify that I have personally examined the affiant and am satisfied that he voluntarily and knowingly executed the foregoing.

(Sgd.) **MA. CRISTIE GIESEL H. MASALANG**
Notary Public for and in the Cities of Pasig and San Juan and in the Municipality of Pateros, Metro Manila
Until 31 December 2024
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EXHIBIT "B-1"

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(MStandard-June 18 & 25, 2024)

PSE clears P580-m IPO of NexGen

By Jenniffer B. Austria

THE Philippine Stock Exchange (PSE) approved the P580 million initial public offering (IPO) of renewable energy producer NexGen Energy Corp. led by the Tiu family.

The PSE said in a memorandum posted on its website NextGen planned to sell up to 300 million shares to the public at an offer price of up to P1.68 apiece.

It said that in case of oversubscription, the company's majority shareholder Pure Energy Holdings Corp. will also offer up to 45 million in over-allotment shares at the same price.

Post-IPO, NextGen will have a market capitalization of P2.5 billion and a public float of 23.15 percent, assuming the oversubscription option is exercised. The offer period will run from July 1, 2024 to July 8, 2024.

The shares will be listed on the Small, Medium and Emerging Board of the PSE on July 16, 2024 under the trading symbol "XG".

NexGen plans to use the net proceeds from the fund-raising activity to partially finance its renewable energy projects in Zambales, Cavite and other parts of the country.

Established in 2017, the company plans to develop solar and wind projects with a capacity of over 2,350 megawatts over the next 10 years.

It has three main subsidiaries, including SPARC-Solar Powered Agri-rural Communities Corp., which operates three solar farms in Zambales, Bataan and Bulacan; 5Hour Peak Energy Corp., which has a pipeline of over 1,000 MW of solar projects; and Airstream Renewables Corp., which has a pipeline of up to 1,330 MW of onshore and offshore wind projects.

PH stock market rebounds 1.8% to end eight-day slump

PHILIPPINE stocks rebounded Monday to end eight straight trading days of decline on bargain-hunting.

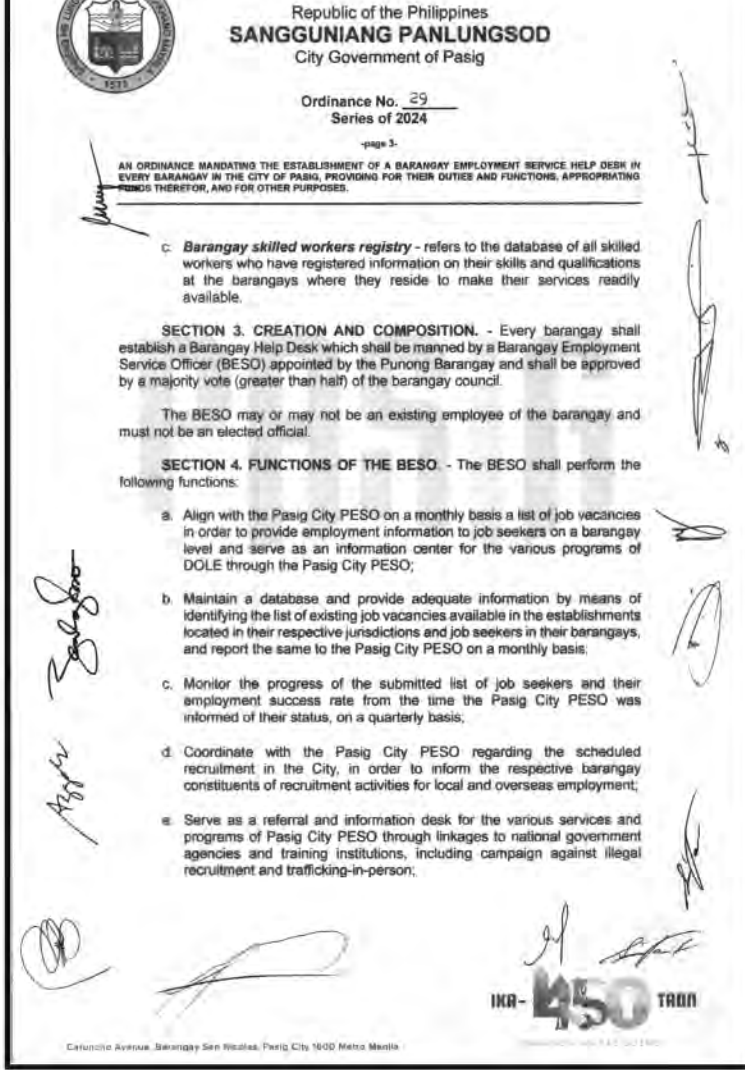
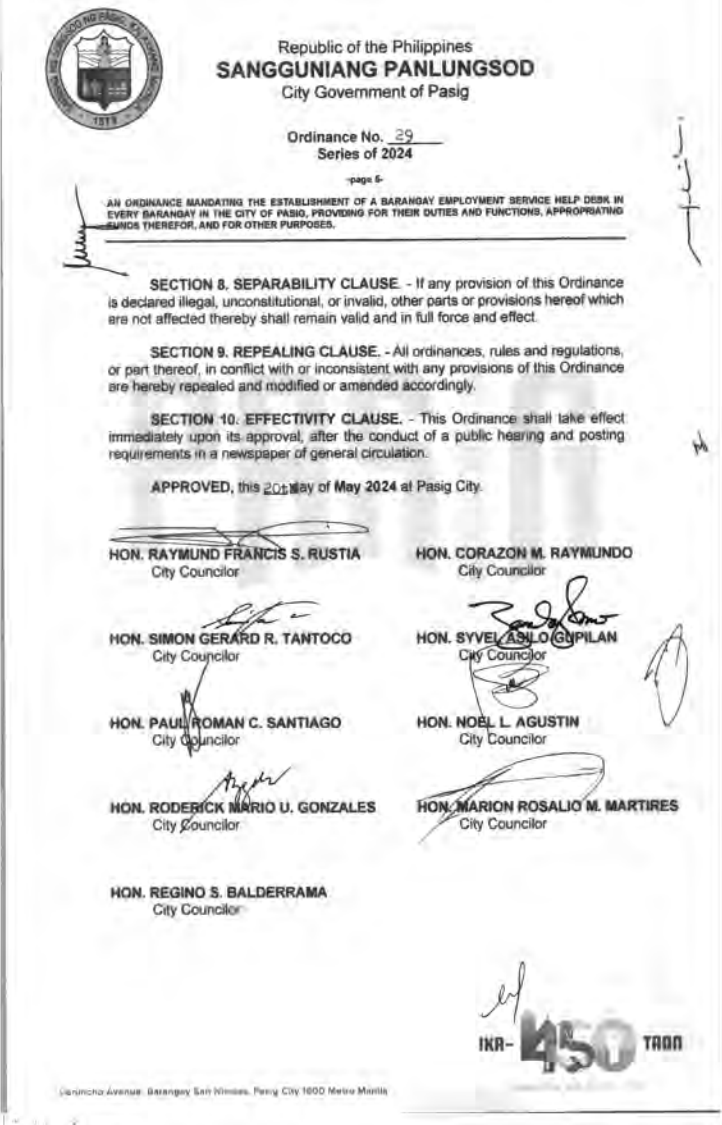
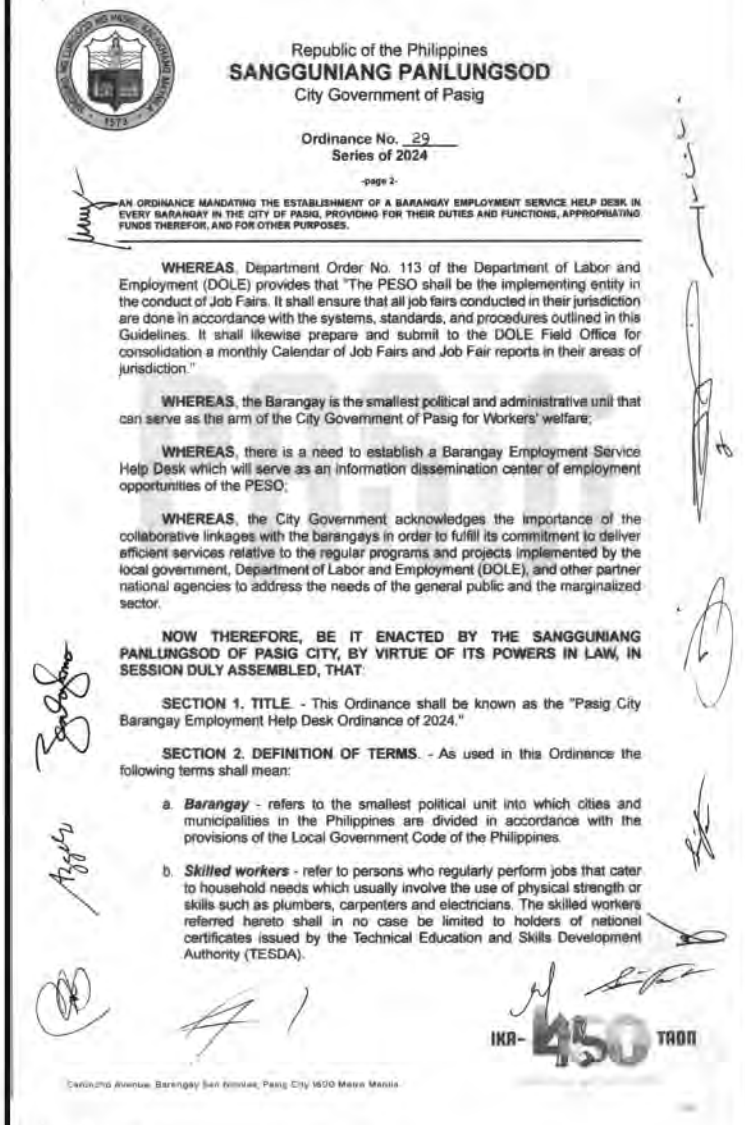
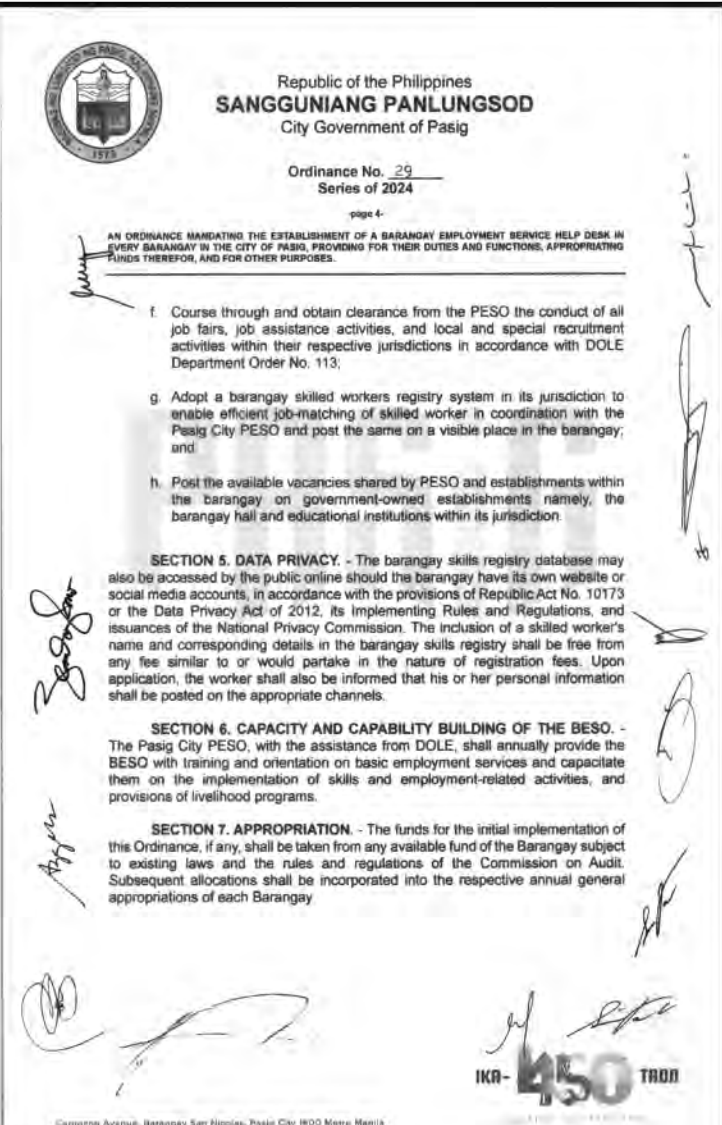
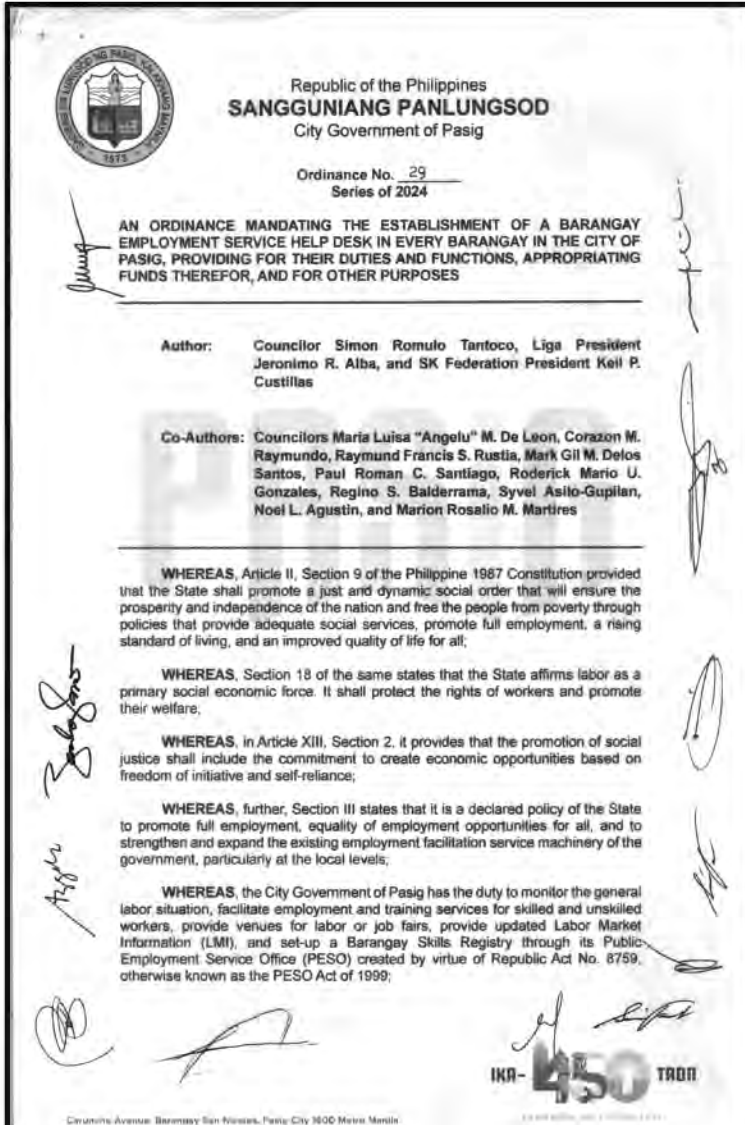
The 30-company Philippine Stock Exchange index returned to the 6,200 level, closing at 6,272.46, up 113.98 points, or 1.8 percent from the previous trading. The broader all-shares index also recovered 32.57 points, or 0.96 percent, to reach

3,407.77.

"Philippine shares made a furious rebound to start the week after dramatic sell-off last Friday as investors went bargain-hunting across the board ahead of window-dressing to end the semester," Regina Capital Development Corp. head of sales Luis Limlingan said.

The market, however, is expected to return to sideways movement in the coming days, as investors await the outcome of policy meeting of the Monetary Board of the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas on Thursday.

Among the six sectoral indices, only mining and oil ended in the red, declining by 0.16 percent. **Jenniffer B. Austria**



GREEN LIGHT
Kiezarie Mae Eve Alfonso

The hallmark of a good leader

DURING a recent CEO series class, we were privileged to have Ms. Hazel Delos Santos as our esteemed guest speaker. My groupmates and I were fortunate to host this enlightening and inspiring session. This elective has become one of the highlights of my MBA journey because it provides me with invaluable insights and motivation from successful leaders.

I am immensely grateful to the CEOs who have taken time out of their hectic schedules to engage with us, inspire us, and motivate us to become good leaders of the future. As Ms. Hazel emphasized, the hallmark of a good leader is the willingness to share, and these CEOs exemplify this trait remarkably.

Ms. Hazel began her talk by sharing her professional journey. She was very transparent about her employment history and the reasons behind her career transitions. Her honesty and bravery in navigating her career path, eagerness to learn, and willingness to step out of her comfort zone make her a role model for the kind of female leader I aspire to be.

As I reflect on Ms. Hazel's insights and my future as a leader, several key messages stand out:

- Lifelong Learning: The eagerness to learn and adapt to new situations highlights the importance of lifelong learning. As a future leader, I will foster a culture of continuous improvement and learning within my organization.

“

I am immensely grateful to the CEOs who have taken time out of their hectic schedules to engage with us, inspire us, and motivate us to become good leaders of the future.

- Courage to Change: Courage to change means being ready to leave behind old habits and comfort zones to find fresh opportunities and innovative approaches to getting where you want to go. This courage is important for personal and professional growth because it leads to progress and a mindset of always getting better and coming up with new ideas.

- Work-Life Balance: Maintaining a healthy work-life balance is crucial for long-term success and well-being. As a leader, I will prioritize and model the importance of balancing professional and personal responsibilities while encouraging my team to do the same.

Meanwhile, as I continue my MBA studies and work towards

becoming a future leader, there are several actions I can take now, based on what I have learned from Ms. Hazel:

- Practice Active Listening: I will actively listen and pose thoughtful inquiries in conversations and meetings. This endeavor will help me see things from other people's points of view and show that I am dedicated to learning.

- Be Prepared: Whether for academic, professional, or networking purposes, I will enter a meeting well-prepared to show my dedication and respect for others' time and knowledge.

- Set Boundaries for Work-Life Balance: I will start setting boundaries for my personal time, such as designated phone-free periods during family time, to cultivate a habit of intentional quality time for the things that matter most.

- Seek Mentorship and Guidance: I will proactively seek mentors and advisers who can assist me in navigating my career progression and provide me with guidance. By integrating knowledge from their experiences, I will enhance my ability to navigate my own journey more effectively.

Ms. Hazel Delos Santos' talk significantly impacted my understanding of leadership and provided me with practical advice that I can use now and in the future. Her dedication to being truthful, brave, and striving for excellence in all aspects of her life—including her family and career—is inspiring. I am motivated to implement these ideas and aspire to become a courageous, compassionate, and accomplished leader as I advance through my MBA program.

The author is an MBA student at the Ramon V. Del Rosario College of Business of De La Salle University. She wrote this reflection paper for her class on Trends and Issues in Business and Management: CEO Series. She can be reached at kiezarie_alfonso@dlsu.edu.ph.

The views expressed above are the author's and do not necessarily reflect the official position of DLSU, its faculty, and its administrators.

Reserve market likely to reopen in July, says ERC

By Alena Mae S. Flores

THE Energy Regulatory Commission (ERC) plans to resume the commercial operations of the reserve market in July 2024 as electricity prices are expected to soften amid cooler temperatures during the rainy season.

“It’s in the agenda of the commission this month. So, most likely by next month or sooner we can already resume the commercial operations,” ERC chairperson Monalisa Dimalanta said.

The reserve market, now integrated into the Wholesale Electricity Spot Market (WESM), the trading floor of electricity, was launched to optimize schedules and prices for energy and reserve requirements, fostering competition and affordability while ensuring grid security and reliability.

Dimalanta said the hydro power plants are expected to be reactivated in September which could impact demand and reduce electricity rates at the WESM.

“So, hopefully we will have some breathing space for the rates, unlike what happened during the summer months,” she said.

Dimalanta said that with the resumption of the operations of the reserve market, the generators would also be paid.

“That’s not a given—the whole remaining amount will be paid. So, that’s part of what we need to deliberate,” Dimalanta said.

The ERC previously ordered the partial lifting of the suspension on settlement amounts in the reserve market to allow power generators to partially recover costs for trading transactions for the March billing month amounting to P1.7 billion, representing 30 percent of the affected transactions. The remaining 70 percent remain unpaid.

The decision was made to ensure the continuous operations of power generators providing reserves in the system following the suspension order issued on March 26, 2024.



Department of Science and Technology-Metals Industry Research and Development Center (DOST-MIRDC) executive director Engr. Robert Dizon (right) hands over a plaque of appreciation to Department of Transportation Undersecretary for railways Jeremy Regino (center) for serving as keynote speaker during the Metals & Engineering Week Industry Forum on June 21, 2024 at the Hilton Manila in Pasay City. Looking on is DOST MIRDC deputy executive director for technical services Engr. Jonathan Puerto.

DOTr to work with DOST on second hybrid electric train

THE Department of Transportation (DOTr) will work with the Department of Science and Technology (DOST) to develop a second, improved prototype of the latter’s Hybrid Electric Train (HET) for use on the Philippine National Railways (PNR) South Long Haul, or Bicol Line.

Transportation Undersecretary for railways Jeremy Regino, in a keynote speech at the Metals & Engineering Week Industry Forum organized by the DOST-Metals Industry Research and Development Center (DOST-MIRDC), said Japanese consultants

for the DOTr approved adopting the HET trains.

Regino said the DOTr and PNR were considering the HET for the PNR South Haul, running from Calamba, Laguna, to Matnog, Sorsogon.

Discussions between DOTr, DOST and Japanese consultants led to a consensus on developing an improved version despite the HET prototype passing evaluation and official test runs.

“It was effective, efficient, safe - a good train we could all be proud of. Proudly made by Filipinos,” Regino

said in his speech.

“We have decided, along with Secretary Renato Solidum of DOST, MIRDC, PNR engineers, and our Japanese consultants, that the hybrid trains of MIRDC and DOST are indeed efficient, effective and a good mode of transportation for us,” Regino said.

“We discussed with MIRDC, DOST, Secretary Solidum, and Secretary Jaime Bautista the possibility of improvements to create a second prototype that would be even safer for riders, personnel, and those operating the trains,” he said.

DOF plans to tap Japan bank on new fundraising activities

By Darwin G. Amojelar

THE Department of Finance (DOF) is eyeing a collaboration with Japan’s Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corp. (SMBC) for upcoming government borrowing activities.

The DOF said in a social media post Secretary Ralph Recto met with senior officials of SMBC and SMBC Nikko on June 21, 2024 at their Tokyo headquarters to explore opportunities for investments and collaboration on fundraising activities.

SMBC is a leading Japanese bank, and SMBC Nikko is a top Japanese securities firm that engages in the operation of large-scale comprehensive securities broking and trading services.

SMBC supported the Philippines’ international financing efforts, including past Samurai bond issuances and co-hosting of Philippine economic briefings in Japan such as the recent event on June 21.

“Moreover, they expressed eagerness to support the country’s future issuances of Samurai and US dollar bonds and reaffirmed SMBC’s commitment to continue investing in the Philippines,” the DOF said.

Recto also met with senior officials of Nomura on June 20, 2024 in Tokyo to explore opportunities for collaboration in the country’s fundraising activities and public-private partnerships (PPPs).

IN BRIEF

Shell PH bullish on bitumen business

SHELL Pilipinas Corp. aims to retain its market leadership in the bitumen business this year, banking on the growth of the economic growth and the booming road construction industry.

Shell Pilipinas country manager for construction and road sector Allan Canedo said the company captured 41 percent of the total bitumen products that arrived in the Philippines in the first quarter of 2024.

Canedo said the company cornered 33 percent of the country’s total bitumen imports in 2023 with bulk of the supply coming from Singapore. “Based on import data that we got from (Bureau of) Customs, the last quarter we were able to get 41 percent of the market. Forty-one percent of the product that arrived in the Philippines,” he said.

Canedo said they are looking at a double-digit volume growth for Shell bitumen this year. **Alena Mae S. Flores**

Emperador allots P6.5b for expansion

LIQUOR firm Emperador Inc. said Monday it earmarked P6.5 billion for 2024 capital expenditures to expand its whisky business overseas.

Emperador president Winston Co said during the company’s annual stockholders meeting the group would complete the expansion of Dalmore distillery in Scotland. The project will double the capacity of the distillery.

The company also started expanding the maturation complex in Invergordon, building more warehouses for whisky aging to house the additional liquid produced by the larger Dalmore distillery.

Co said the company remained on expansion mode despite challenges both in the domestic and international markets. “We have seen some challenges in North America, in China, but your company had stayed resilient. We will continue to performance hopefully better than last year,” Co said. **Jennifer B. Austria**

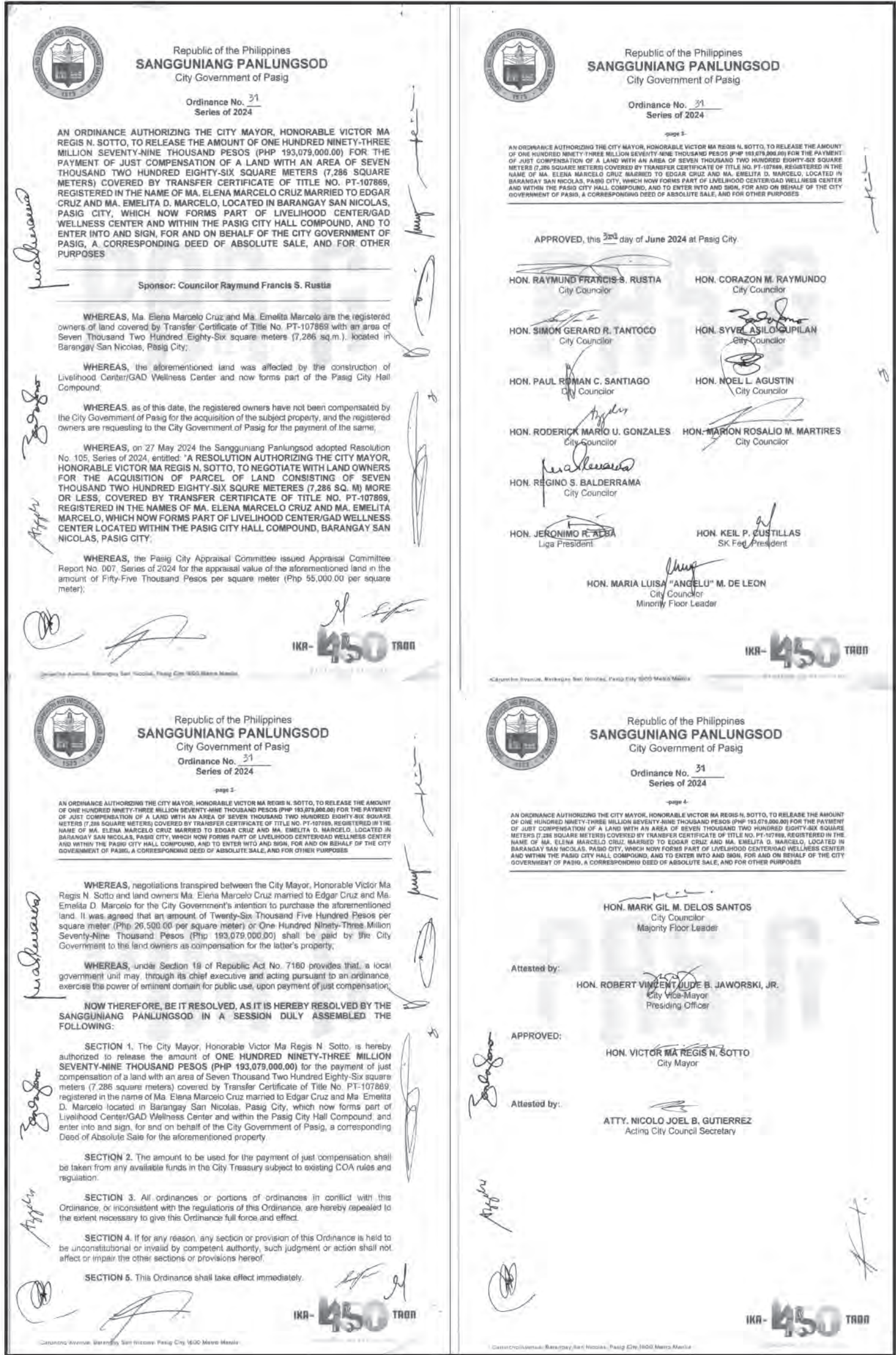
Globe transfers 48 towers to PhilTower

GLOBE Telecom said Monday it transferred an additional 48 towers to PhilTower Consortium Inc. for P710 million.

The latest batch brought the total number of transferred towers to 1,148 worth P14.7 billion out of the total 1,350 towers. The total value of the entire deal is estimated at P20 billion.

“The transaction will result in availability of funds for Globe to support future capital expenditures, debt repayments and debt avoidance with the expectation to improve the balance sheet health of the company,” Globe said.

Globe agreed in August 2022 to sell then leaseback all its 5,709 telecommunications tower and relative passive infrastructure in two deals worth P71 billion. About 2,180 towers will be sold to MIDC for P26 billion while the remaining 3,529 towers will be sold to Frontier Tower Associates Philippines Inc. for P45 billion. **Darwin G. Amojelar**



Philippines' largest hotel inaugurated in Megaworld's Westside City



President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. (center) leads the inauguration of the Grand Westside Hotel

IF THE official launch of Megaworld's Grand Westside Hotel in Parañaque City were an entertainment event, it could easily be described as star-studded with none other than the country's highest government official in attendance.

President **Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr.** on Saturday led the inauguration of the Philippines' biggest hotel. He was welcomed by Alliance Global Group, Inc., president and chief executive officer **Kevin Tan**.

Other prominent personalities joining the president were Speaker **Martin Romualdez**, Tourism Secretary **Christina Frasco**, Trade Secretary **Alfredo Pascual**, Philippine Amusement and Gaming Corp. chairman **Alejandro Tengco**, and Parañaque City Mayor **Eric Olivarez**.

During his speech, Marcos said the 19-story establishment with over 1,500 rooms would not only strengthen the government's tourism campaign but would also generate more jobs and business opportunities for Filipinos.

"Thanks to this hotel, we can do more. Not only can we accommodate the resurging number of local and international tourists coming to this side of Metro Manila, but we can



Very Wang
Nickie Wang

also expect our Entertainment City to become better known and even more distinguished, elevating its status to more potential visitors in the coming years," Marcos elaborated.

The President also said the hotel's addition to Philippine tourism is particularly noteworthy in light of the sector's "remarkable" growth, which contributed 8.6 percent to the country's gross domestic product in 2023.

"With all these, we foresee not only the entry of more tourists but also the generation of more jobs, of new businesses, and greater opportunity. In fact, [while] many have benefitted from the actual construction of these [properties], around 20,000 direct and indirect jobs will still be created throughout the operation of this hotel

in the years to come," he added.

Located within Megaworld's 31-hectare Westside City township at the bustling Entertainment City in Parañaque City, Grand Westside Hotel offers a variety of room types and sizes, bannered by presidential suites that feature its own living, dining, and kitchen spaces. Other room types include Queen Suites, Twin Suites, and Executive Suites. It will also have dedicated rooms designed specifically for specially-abled guests.

"Grand Westside Hotel is the latest addition to Megaworld's Westside City township, which continues to take shape today as the 'Broadway of Asia.' The hotel offers guests a wide variety of room selections, each one designed for the varied preferences of guests, whether they are traveling for business or leisure. Even more exciting is the fact that the hotel sits along Manila Bay, which allows guests to marvel and enjoy the captivating sunset from this side of Metro Manila," said **Cleofe Albiso**, managing director, Megaworld Hotels & Resorts.



The facade of the 19-story Grand Westside Hotel in Parañaque

The Grand Westside Hotel offers diverse dining options, including Café by Westside, an all-day restaurant serving Filipino and international cuisines, the Zabana Bar on the ground floor, and the Plunge Bar on the fifth-floor open deck. LaMeza, a specialty restaurant, will open later this year.

Inspired by waves approaching the shore, the hotel features a two-level retail and commercial space. Guests are greeted by a high-ceiling lobby with a contemporary design using natural elements. The fifth floor boasts first-class amenities, including a pool

with Manila Bay sunset views, a children's pool, gazebo, Zen garden, and an outdoor seating area with colorful shrubs.

Function rooms cater to various events, while a fitness gym, massage rooms, and an Executive Lounge for VIP guests complete the amenities. The hotel will be connected to the upcoming Westside Resort complex, featuring four theaters, including the 2,000-seat Grand Opera House.

Celebrating Megaworld's 35th anniversary, the Grand Westside Hotel supports Philippine tourism and job creation. Megaworld committed P64 billion to develop Westside City within 10 years. The hotel, managed by Megaworld Hotels & Resorts, is the second in Westside City, following the 529-room Kingsford Hotel Manila.

Megaworld Hotels & Resorts has launched 20 hotel properties across the Philippines, including Richmond Hotels, Savoy Hotels, Belmont Hotels, Kingsford Hotels, Twin Lakes Hotel, Hotel Lucky Chinatown, ArcoVia Hotel, Paragua Sands Hotel, and Chancellor Hotel Boracay.

You won't believe what happened at the first-ever Pride Run at SM Mall of Asia

THE SM by the Bay at the SM Mall of Asia (MOA) Complex was transformed into a thrilling, inclusive celebration as SM Supermalls, in collaboration with RunRio, hosted SM Supermalls' first-ever Pride Run on Saturday, June 22, 2024. The event brought together thousands of Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transsexual, Queer, Intersex, and Asexual (LGBTQIA+) members and allies for a day of unity, excitement, and unforgettable moments.

A Historic First: The energy was electric as over 5,000 runners gathered for 10km, 5km, and 3km races. Decked out in Pride Run singlets, race bibs, and timing chips, participants were ready to hit the pavement and make history.

Who Stole the Show? Among the standout moments, Juan Karlo Igos clinched first place in the 10km race with an impressive time of 38 minutes and 11 seconds, while Cavin Vedal dominated the 5km race, crossing the finish line in just 16 minutes and 47 seconds. But the real showstoppers were the participants' dazzling outfits, turning the run into a runway of creativity.

Celebs and Influencers Spotted: The event saw appearances from notable personalities including Pantay Inc. Chairperson Thysz Estrada, actor Gardo Versoza, and popular content creator Minnie Nato. Their presence added a touch of star power to the already glittering event.

Epic Performances: The finish line was just the beginning of the fun! The crowd was treated to electrifying performances by artists Dey XD, Andy Crocker, Moonlight, and the sensational Taylor Swift, whose performance had everyone dancing and singing along.



From left: RunRio president Rio de la Cruz, SM Supermalls' vice president for corporate marketing Grace Magno, 10k race category winner Juan Carlo Igos, BingoPlus Foundation executive director Angela Wieneke, and LoveYourselfPH head of administration and business development Calvin June Sintoy



3km runners take off at the starting line of the 2024 Pride Run at SM by the Bay, SM Mall of Asia Complex.



Participants champion a more inclusive society at Pride Run 2024.



Content creator Minnie Nato



Taylor Swift impersonator, Taylor Swift, charms the crowd at Pride Run 2024 with a lively performance.



Pantay Inc. Chairperson Thysz Estrada



Actor Gardo Versoza

Costume Extravaganza: The much-anticipated Costume Contest did not disappoint. From superhero ensembles to playful banana costumes, participants went all out, adding an extra layer of fun to the festivities. The creativity and effort were truly a sight to behold.

A Symbol of Inclusivity: The event was more than just a run; it was a powerful statement of support and inclusivity for the LGBTQIA+ community. With partners like ArenaPlus, BingoPlus Foundation, LoveYourselfPH, Pantay Inc., and the Metro Manila Pride Organization, the Pride Run proved to

be a monumental celebration of diversity.

Don't Miss Out: Missed the Pride Run? Catch up on all the highlights and see why this event is the talk of the town. For more amazing events and programs, visit www.smsupermalls.com or follow @SMSupermalls on social media.

DOT seeks to liberalize visa policies to boost cruise tourism in PH

By Angelica Villanueva

THE Department of Tourism (DOT) is setting its sights on making the Philippines a top cruise destination in Asia by relaxing visa policies for cruise passengers and improving cruise tourism infrastructure around the country.

During her speech at the Philippine Tourism and Hotel Investment Summit in Makati City on Friday, June 21, DOT Secretary **Christina Frasco** announced plans for the “liberalization” of visa requirements for cruise ship visitors.

“The DOT is working very closely with

the Bureau of Immigration on the aspect of the liberalization of cruise tourism visas—an announcement will be made very soon on this aspect,” said Frasco.

The said plans came after collaboration with the Bureau of Immigration to address concerns raised by cruise lines, particularly regarding limitations on same-day visas for Chinese nationals.

Frasco also emphasized the DOT’s commitment to expanding the number of Philippine destinations cruise ships can visit.

“I assure our stakeholders in the cruise tourism industry *na ang focus ng DOT ay*



The Department of Tourism aims to make the Philippines a top cruise destination in Asia

ang pag-expand ng number of cruise tourism destinations *sa Pilipinas*,” she added.

This aligns with the Philippine Ports Authority’s (PPA) plan to construct new cruise ports in Coron, Siargao, Camiguin, Boracay, and Puerto Galera. These new ports will add to existing ones in Currimao (Ilocos Norte), Salomague (Ilocos Sur), Manila, Bohol, and El Nido (Palawan).

The Philippines’ cruise tourism industry has already seen positive growth. In 2023, there were 125 cruise calls, bringing over 100,000 passengers. So far in 2024 (as of May 28), there have been 117 cruise calls with an estimated 123,000 passengers. The DOT’s efforts aim to further accelerate this growth and solidify the Philippines’ position as a premier cruise destination.

Jolina Magdangal returns to soap operas with ‘Lavender Fields’



Shticks
Joseph Peter Gonzales

AFTER nearly a decade away from the soap opera scene, **Jolina Magdangal** is set to make her comeback in Dreamscape Entertainment’s latest series, *Lavender Fields*. She will star alongside **Jericho Rosales**, **Jodi Sta. Maria**, and **Janine Gutierrez**, taking on the role of Lily Atienza.

In a statement, the bubbly singer-actress-host expressed her surprise and excitement upon being contacted for the role.

“I was surprised myself when Dreamscape contacted me and offered the part. I instantly got excited! The feeling is like, ‘Is this true?’ I’ve been hosting for so long, and it’s been ages since I last did a soap. When I found out, I felt a mix of excitement and nervousness,” the ‘90s star said.

Magdangal also shared her enthusiasm about working with her co-stars, many of whom she has not collaborated with before. “Yes, most of them, I haven’t worked with before. This will be the first time I’ll share the screen with them. Like Jodi, it’s exciting to work with her. We did projects together when we were younger, but this time it’s different. I watch her soaps and admire her acting skills. My mom and I are fans of her acting.”

“With Echo, we’ve been together in lots of shows abroad in the past like in TFC but this will be the first time that we’ll collaborate on a soap. So, it excites me to do a soap with him now that we’re adults.

“As for Janine, I worked with her in GMA before but that was hosting. She was just new then. I’m thrilled because now, we’re co-actors in this new soap. I’ve watched her past programs and she’s a good actress. At least, it’s a fresh screen cast so I hope the viewers will support our offering.”

Interestingly, what can she promise her loyal fans now that she’s back doing soaps?

“They will see a different Jolina in *Lavender Fields*. It’s different from the Momshie Jolina that they see every day in *Magandang Buhay*. They will see a different facet of mine with the show. If they got excited with this development, more so with me. So, hope they watch out for it,” Jolina ended.

Regine Tolentino looked her pretty and glowing self as she recently hosted the launching of Belle Blush & Glow Skin Essentials, a rising beauty product line in the market. Here, she gave updates on her current projects and plans.

“Well, my boutique recently celebrated its 25th anniversary and I feel proud and happy that we’ve come this far. I still run my dance studio and we opened a branch in Pasig,” she averred.

The dancer-actress-host is also busy with her Zumba tour.

“I make the rounds in some key provinces. I will be in Cagayan, Laguna, and Bicol. I will also fly to Canada and Japan. It’s fun!”

Many are curious if despite her packed schedule, she still misses acting.

“My doors are very open to acting projects as long as my schedule permits. I’m open to doing soap operas again. I miss tapings and shootings. Next year, I’ll be more visible. Hopefully, I can do a dance movie with **Mark Herras** and **Maja Salvador** if she already can.”

Incidentally, Belle Blush and Glow owned by politician-businesswoman **Maribel Frias Vitales** is presently searching for celebrity endorsers. If offered, will she accept it?

“Of course, why not? I want to help the business because it’s not only concerned about making its clientele beautiful but also giving them work as sub-retailers.”



Actress Jolina Magdangal takes on the role of Lily Atienza in ‘Lavender Fields’



Free collaborative platform Online Alerto aims to raise awareness about dating scams



Online Alerto shares several steps to help protect people from scams as they try to look for love online

DATING in the digital age has become easier with numerous apps and services. By the end of 2023, 441 million people actively used dating apps, generating \$8.7 billion in global revenues.

Dating apps allow you to meet people beyond geographical limits, see their profiles, and interests, and chat to assess compatibility before meeting in person.

Is your online lover too good to be true?

Know the red flags of a love scammer

Many Filipinos have fallen victim to romance scams online. To combat this, the Facebook page Online Alerto crowdsources information to raise awareness about scams. It offers insights, resources, and strategies on digital literacy, cybersecurity, and responsible online behavior.

Online Alerto is a free collaborative platform where members can validate online purchases and share personal experiences to enhance online safety. While identity theft and hacking are the leading global cybercrimes, love scams are rapidly rising, especially in Southeast Asia, affecting both victims and trafficked scammers.

Online Alerto provides warnings and tips on avoiding love scams.

Avoid these red flags

The person expresses strong emotions and love for you quickly, often within days or weeks of initial contact.

They quickly ask you to leave a dating service or social media site to communicate directly on WhatsApp or SMS, where they can manipulate you more easily.

If an individual attempts to isolate you from friends and family or requests

inappropriate photos or financial information, they could later blackmail you or extort money from you.

When you make plans to meet in person, they always come up with an excuse why they can’t.

They ask for money for various reasons such as travel expenses, medical emergencies, or business opportunities. This is often the biggest and most obvious red flag.

They tell you stories to elicit sympathy, such as being widowed, having a sick child, or facing some urgent crisis.

They ask you many questions, but they avoid sharing their personal details or giving information that cannot be verified, such as a home address or workplace.

What scammers say to hook you in

“I or someone close to me is sick, hurt, or in jail.”

“I can teach you how to invest.”

“I’m in the military far away.”

“I need help with an important delivery.”

“We’ve never met, but let’s talk about marriage.”

“I’ve come into some money or gold.”

“I’m on an oil rig or ship.”

“You can trust me with your private

pictures.”

Ways to protect yourself

Reverse search the person’s photo by using online searches like Google Images.

Be careful what you post and make public online. Scammers use details shared on social media and dating sites to better understand and target you.

Maintain a healthy level of skepticism, especially if things seem too good to be true.

Suggest a video call early in your communication.

Check their social media profiles for consistency with what they’ve told you. Look for a reasonable number of friends, photos, and posts over time. A lack of social media presence or a newly created profile can be a red flag.

If you decide to meet in person, choose a public place and inform a friend or family member about your plans. Ensure the person you meet matches their online presence.

Some dating apps offer identity verification features, like blue checkmarks, to indicate users who have verified their identity through the app.

Join Online Alerto on Facebook to better protect yourself from romance and other scams and learn from other people’s experiences.



Gloc-9 (left) with Sandwich member Raymund Marasigan



Gloc-9 is known for songs that shed light on social issues

By Angelica Villanueva

RAPPER-SINGER **Gloc-9** has been a prominent figure in the music industry for over two decades, establishing himself as a household name in the local hip-hop scene with his hard-hitting rap and insightful lyrics.

His ascent in the hip-hop community stemmed from his skill in crafting intricate tales that resonate with the Filipino experience, addressing a variety of social issues such as poverty, equality, and corruption. Before dominating Filipino hip-hop music, Gloc-9 revealed it was only a dream of him to do rapping, but now, the result of his

perseverance to do what he loved was just overwhelming—it was beyond what he once dreamed of. “When I did what I wished for when I was 12 years old—to rap,” he told the *Manila Standard Entertainment* when asked what was his greatest “sari-sari” story. After spending so many years in the industry, Gloc-9 had heard countless stories from people he met, skillfully weaving them into the hit songs that became familiar to us all through his masterful storytelling. Recently, Gloc-9 did it once again as he dropped his latest full-length album titled “Sari-Sari Story”, consisting of 10 tracks, including “Panulat Mo”, “Gatas at Asukal”, “Utang Clan”, “Puyat”, “Sagip”, “Tinda Ni Linda”, “Tatlong Taon”, “Alimpungatan”, “Yakap”, at “IDOL”. Talking about his latest music, the iconic musician delved into how **Sandwich’s Raymond Marasigan** had



The cover art for Gloc-9's 10-track album ‘Sari-Sari Story’

helped him in producing his album for six weeks before he went to Australia for a tour. “My inspiration for the album is

reflected in its title. Kuya [Raymund] and I made an effort to clearly define the album’s title. However, I think we already had two songs created at that time—‘Utang Clan’ and ‘Gatas at Asukal’. We identified a title that made it easier for me to write songs under the theme of ‘Sari-Sari Story’, prompting me to think of various narratives while maintaining uniformity in our topic selection,” Gloc-9 explained in the vernacular. Despite his reputation for social consciousness, his songs connect with common people, touching every kid who grew up listening to him and inspiring every aspiring musician who looks up to him. With his numerous tracks, his focus now goes to his artistry. “I think *kapag umabot ka na nang mga* above 45, *hindi mo na inisip*

iyon, medyo may stable ka na, mas sa iyo ‘yung artistry. *Kahit naman noon, although noon mas mahigpit ako sa sarili ko,*” said Gloc-9. “*Pero ngayon ang* goal is to write songs that I love, that we love, *na ‘pag okay sa amin,* anything after that bonus *na lang. Iyon lagi ang goal—makasulat kami, maka-produce kami ng* output, *kanta na trip namin para kaya naming ilako,*” he added. The rapper icon then turned to the up-and-coming hip-hop artists of today’s generation to “take care of the fire” they have in creating music. “I always say, especially to the newcomers today, nurture the fire inside you because it can fade. I appreciate the support from Kuya Rayms and all my inspiring friends who fuel my creativity with their perseverance. “There have been times after writing countless songs when I struggled to find inspiration, but being around the new generation rejuvenates me. They help me as much as I help them,” Gloc-9 explained.



K-pop girl group Red Velvet is known for their hit songs ‘Psycho,’ ‘Russian Roulette,’ and many more

K-pop sensation Red Velvet to kick off first fan-con tour

GLOBAL K-pop group **Red Velvet** will hold its first-ever fan-con tour, *2024 Red Velvet Fancon Tour <Happiness: My Dear, ReVeluv>*, in Manila on Sept. 14 at the SM Mall of Asia Arena. The fan-con will feature live performances of the group’s popular hits and songs from its upcoming album, *Cosmic*, set to be released soon. Debating under SM Entertainment in 2014, Red Velvet has earned international recognition for its dynamic performances, versatile music style, and captivating vocals. This year marks a decade since its

debut, and the fan-con tour will celebrate its 10th anniversary. Over the years, Red Velvet has enthralled audiences worldwide with chart-topping hits such as “Psycho,” “Bad Boy,” “Russian Roulette,” “Red Flavor,” “Feel My Rhythm,” and many more. Tickets for the *2024 Red Velvet Fancob Tour <Happiness: My Dear, ReVeluv>* in Manila will be available starting July 27 at 11:00 a.m. via SMTickets.com and all SM Tickets outlets nationwide. The fan-con is presented by Applewood and Wilbros Live.

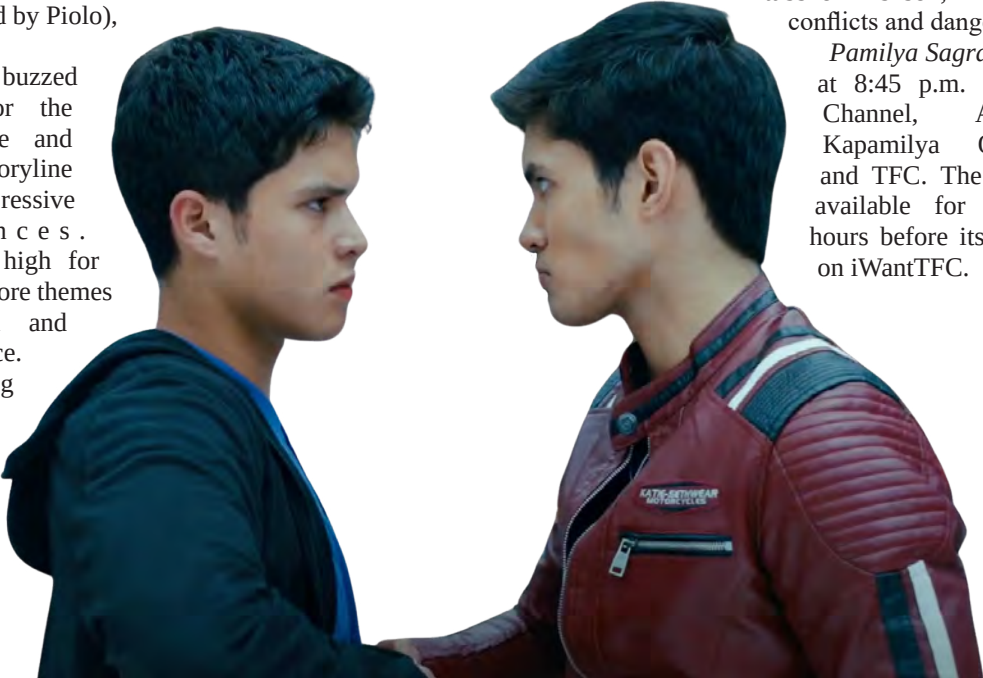
‘Pamilya Sagrado’ debuts with strong viewership, social media buzz

ABS-CBN’s latest family drama series, *Pamilya Sagrado*, captivated audiences with its premiere, achieving 443,269 peak live concurrent views on Kapamilya Online Live and trending widely on social media. The show, featuring stars **Piolo Pascual**, **Kyle Echarri**, and **Grae Fernandez**, airs weeknights on Kapamilya Channel, A2Z, and TV5. The debut episode, which aired on Monday, June 17, introduced viewers to college students Moises and Justin (played by Kyle and Grae). The characters’ relationship began with a heated confrontation when Justin accidentally ran over Moises, leading to an unexpected friendship. Additionally, viewers got a glimpse of the corrupt nature of Governor Rafael (portrayed by Piolo), Justin’s father. Social media buzzed with praise for the show’s relatable and compelling storyline and the cast’s impressive performances. Anticipation is high for the series to explore themes of brotherhood and fraternity violence. Upcoming episodes promise more gripping drama as the dark secrets of the Sagrado family unfold. Tensions are set to rise as



Piolo Pascual (right) stars as Governor Rafael in ‘Pamilya Sagrado’

Governor Rafael hires Moises to keep tabs on his son, hinting at future conflicts and dangers. *Pamilya Sagrado* weeknights at 8:45 p.m. on Kapamilya Channel, A2Z, TV5, Kapamilya Online Live, and TFC. The series is also available for streaming 48 hours before its TV broadcast on iWantTFC.



Kyle Echarri (left) plays the role of college student Moises alongside Grae Fernandez who portrays Governor Rafael’s son Justin

Managing water key to food security —CCC head

THE Climate Change Commission (CCC) asked Filipinos to engage in effective land restoration and water management to enhance resilience against environmental challenges.

The CCC made the call last week in observance of the World Day to Combat Desertification and Drought.

Desertification is the degradation of land resulting primarily from climatic variations and human activities. It reduces soil’s ability to support crops, which leads to lower yields and increased food scarcity.

Drought, on the other hand, is a natural phenomenon characterized by a prolonged period of abnormally low rainfall that leads to a shortage of water. It affects drinking water supplies, agriculture and industrial activities.

With climate change, desertification and droughts are expected to worsen and intensify. This loss affects ecosystems’ ability to function and provide essential services. The degradation of land and water resources leads to malnutrition, poverty and displacement, especially in vulnerable communities in developing regions.

According to the United Nations, up to 40 percent of the world’s land is already considered degraded. Degraded lands release stored carbon into the atmosphere, which contributes to climate change.

The CCC urged the public to take concerted action in land restoration and water management to reduce the impacts of these threats, and in effect, climate change.

“Addressing desertification and drought is crucial for our nation’s resilience and food security,” said Secretary Robert Borje, CCC vice chairperson and executive director. “We must act collectively to restore degraded lands and manage our water resources sustainably.” **CCC News**

A CUP OF TEA... OR CHA?

Celebrating tea as part of our heritage and history

Conclusion

THIS site also developed a certification system and product label to indicate the degree of farmers’ engagement in the Chagusaba methods which reflect the contribution to biodiversity conservation. This informs the consumers about good agricultural practices in the production process, incentivizing them to purchase tea products that are grown sustainably.

The Traditional Hadong tea agrosystem is an agricultural system created by local communities based on 1, 200 years of adaptation to the barren environment of Jiri Mountain. Over 90 percent of the Hwagae-myeon area is steep mountainous land with frequent flooding during the monsoon season, making stable agricultural activities here very difficult. The people of Hwagae rely on tea agriculture instead of rice paddies to make their living.

Over the last 1,200 years Hadong tea plants have adapted to the harsh environment, reproducing via insects and the wind, giving each tea field genetic diversity. The tea fields around Hwagae stream at the foot of the mountain exist in harmony with the surrounding natural environment, maintaining excellent biodiversity. Varieties of traditional Hadong tea plants are numerous, encouraging biodiversity in the area. Forests and rivers provide a home for diverse species of animals and plants indigenous to the Jiri Mountain area.

Tea has travelled across the world over the centuries, from its origins in China thousands of years ago to its status as a household staple for many across the world today. Tea production and processing is a main source of livelihoods for millions of families in low and middle-income countries. **FAO News**



The Hadong traditional tea agricultural system is Hwage-myum residents’ 1,200 years of adaptation to the barren environment of the mountainous terrain of Jiri Mountain nature. **FAO photo**

Holcim adopts circular economy to cut waste, conserve resources



The Circular Explorer, aside from being a waste collection and research vessel, serves as a platform to advance discussion on the importance of circularity in sustainable development.

LEADING cement company Holcim Philippines Inc. has called for an accelerated shift to circularity to help the country reduce waste and conserve virgin natural resources while advancing development.

Circularity is helping the company’s business and environmental performance and it believes the country can similarly benefit from such practices. The company has become among the country’s top recyclers, having reused over a million tons of waste in 2023 from industrial and local government partners in producing cement.

Circularity has also enabled Holcim Philippines to reduce freshwater withdrawals in operations since 2018 which is driven by water recycling and improvements in efficiency.

Holcim Philippines is working with stakeholders to similarly rethink wastes as alternatives to virgin materials, especially construction demolition materials which can be reused in building new structures without compromising performance.

The company is stepping up interactions with clients, building industry professionals, and government authorities on the practice, noting that this is steadily gaining ground in other countries.

Holcim Philippines is well positioned to support local partners interested in using circular construction materials given its access to expertise and the latest technology from the Holcim Group, the global leader in innovative and sustainable building solutions.

In 2023, the Holcim Group recycled nearly 8.4 million tons of construction demolition materials and aims to reach at least 10 million tons by 2025.

“Advances in technology and design allow us to repurpose construction demolition materials instead of using virgin resources in new structures. This practice is relevant to the Philippines and we are excited to work with partners to accelerate its adoption locally,” said Holcim Philippines chief sustainability officer Sam Manlosa Jr.

Aside from practicing circularity and sharing its expertise, Holcim Philippines is engaged in a campaign on the benefits of the practice to the youth, scientific community and policymakers. The main tool is Circular Explorer, a waste collection and research vessel co-developed with German environmental group One Earth, One Ocean Foundation to support the rehabilitation of Manila Bay.

Although Circular Explorer’s waste collection efforts are the first to grab attention, it is moving on several fronts to highlight the critical role of circularity in addressing the waste that comes with growth.

The Circular Explorer is equipped with a compact set of oceanographic sensors and a microplastic collector to support research by UP Marine Science Institute. It is also supporting the Plastics Research Intensive Methods Training Program to capacitate 80 early-career researchers and faculty members from 50 universities and government agencies across the Philippines.

PH mining must be sustainable, says DENR chief

ENVIRONMENT and Natural Resources Secretary Maria Antonia Yulo Loyzaga urged the mining industry to innovate the way it develops the country’s natural resources and align with the principles of sustainability, stewardship and resilience.

“Our nation is at a pivotal juncture where the need to balance economic growth with environmental protection has never been more pressing. And while climate change has increased the complexity of risk across different scales and sectors, it also now represents opportunities for reform in this particular sector and industry,”

the DENR chief said during a mining forum held in Makati City last week.

Loyzaga said the Philippines must leverage its natural wealth responsibly and equitably and ensure that the socio-economic benefits of mining extend to all Filipinos, especially to the communities that host mining operations and those beyond.

Sweden acknowledged during the forum it organized with the Chamber of Mines in the Philippines that the Southeast Asian country is endowed with rich mineral resources with a combined value of between \$0.4 trillion to 1 trillion. Critical minerals that are vital to the

manufacture of chip-driven gadgets and electric vehicle batteries such as gold, copper and nickel are among the Philippines’ leading mineral exports providing the country with a unique opportunity to become a global leader in sustainable mining.

Loyzaga said the forum is an important platform for collaboration crucial to advancing Philippine Development Goals and international commitments to the Paris Agreement, Convention on Biodiversity, Sustainable Development Goals, Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction, among others.

DENR News



Proceeds donated to Urban Farmers PH from Kenny Rogers Roasters 3rd Farmvocacy program are used to support the Taguig Integrated School and Barrio Obrero Elementary School, where each received P150,000 to provide essential resources for their plant beds, seedling nurseries and technical training in urban farming.

Kenny Rogers Roasters supports local farmers

FOOD becomes even more enjoyable and meaningful when it is prepared with compassion and support for others.

This is the aim of Kenny Rogers Roasters as it held its third Farmvocacy Program. Rooted on its message, “Eat Healthy, Help Greatly,” the program fosters a farm-to-table approach where every purchase of Kenny Rogers Roasters’ selected menu item provides support to local farmers.

On its third year, the program selected its well-loved Chimichurri Roast, whose ingredients are sourced locally, as the featured dish.

Early this year, customers who ordered the Chimichurri Roast Solo Plate, through dine-in, takeout or delivery, also helped Kenny Rogers support Urban Farmers PH—an organization that nurtures unused public spaces, inviting people to discover that farming is enjoyable, doable, and transferrable. For every

purchase of Chimichurri Roast, a portion was donated to Urban Farmers PH.

Through the Farmvocacy Program, the roast chicken restaurant chain has accumulated a total of P300,000. The proceeds donated to Urban Farmers PH were used to support the Taguig Integrated School and Barrio Obrero Elementary School, providing essential resources for their plant beds, seedling nurseries, and technical training in urban farming.

Through the initiatives, Urban Farmers PH is instilling the value and appreciation for agriculture among young urban dwellers while fostering healthy eating.

The support aims to further strengthen the momentum of urban farming in the Philippines. Even with challenges like limited space and access to resources, the program helped urban farming in the country thrive, offering a promising means for sustainable urban development and improved food access.

New UNICEF report bares deadly and growing impact of air pollution

THE United Nations last week warned that air pollution is increasingly impacting human health—and is now the second leading global risk factor for premature death.

The UN aired the alert following the release of the State of Global Air (SoGA) report published in partnership with the UN Children’s Fund (UNICEF).

The fifth edition of the report, released by the Health Effects Institute (HEI), revealed that air pollution caused 8.1 million deaths worldwide in 2021 and many millions are dealing with debilitating chronic diseases, leaving

healthcare systems, economies and societies.

It found that children under five are particularly vulnerable to air pollution, leaving over 700,000 in this age group dead in 2021.

The SoGA report found that pollutants like outdoor fine particulate matter (PM2.5), which comes from burning fossil fuels and biomass in sectors like transportation, residential homes, wildfires, and more, caused more than 90 percent of global air pollution deaths and were found to be the “most consistent and accurate predictor of poor health outcomes around the

world.”

Other pollutants like household air pollution, ozone (O3) and nitrogen dioxide (NO2)—which can be found in traffic exhaust—also contribute to the global deterioration of human health.

HEI president Dr. Elena Craft said she hopes the information in the report will inspire change.

“Air pollution has enormous implications for health. We know that improving air quality and global public health is practical and achievable,” she said. **UN News**